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Dowry case: Woman dies, in-laws held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Noida

Her family spent nearly a crore for the wedding. A year and a half later, the 25-year-old woman died allegedly after jumping from the terrace of her three-storey matrimonial house in Uttar Pradesh's Gautam Buddh Nagar district following harassment by her in-laws over dowry. The woman's 26-year-old husband and father-in-law have been arrested, the police said, adding they are investigating the matter even as the woman's family alleged she was killed for dowry by the in-laws.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Shailendra Kumar Singh said a complaint was received at Ecotech-3 police station regarding the death of Deepika, who got married around a year and a half ago to Hrithik, a resident of Jalpura village.

Deepika died after jumping from the terrace on Sunday night, allegedly driven to despair by the harassment, the officer said. A case was registered based on a written complaint by the woman's father.

Police said the woman's husband, Hrithik and father-in-law Manoj were arrested and further legal proceedings were on. In his complaint, Deepika's father, Sanjay Nagar, alleged that he received a phone call from his



Family members mourn after a woman allegedly died by suicide over dowry harassment in Greater Noida on Monday. Police said the husband and father-in-law have been arrested

daughter on Sunday afternoon during which she was crying and told him that her in-laws were assaulting her over dowry demands. He alleged that the in-laws were demanding a Toyota Fortuner SUV and an additional ₹45-50 lakh in cash as dowry.

Nagar, maintains that he gave ₹11 lakh in cash, gold worth ₹50 lakh, furniture and a Scorpio car during the wedding in December 2024. Deepika's father, accompanied by a few relatives, reportedly visited the in-laws' house the same evening and tried to resolve the dispute.

Nagar said that around 7 pm, he, along with some associates,

went to his daughter's matrimonial home. In this three-storey independent house, discussions were held with the in-laws in an attempt to resolve the issue.

He said that around 12.30 am, he received a call from her in-laws informing him that his daughter had fallen from the roof of the house and got injured and asking the family to reach Sharda Hospital directly. "When I reached the hospital, I found my daughter lying dead," Nagar said, adding that the body had injury marks too.

In his complaint, Nagar named seven persons who were allegedly present in the house

at the time of the incident, including Hrithik and Manoj, both of whom were arrested on Monday morning. The incident came months after another alleged dowry death in Greater Noida in August 2025, when a woman identified as Nikki Bhati was allegedly set ablaze by her husband and in-laws over a demand for ₹36 lakh.

Speaking to reporters on Monday, Sanjay Nagar alleged, "They killed my daughter over a Fortuner car and cash. I gave them a Scorpio N and cash on various occasions, but they killed her. I want justice from the Government." Police said efforts

were on to arrest the remaining accused named in the complaint. "The husband, Hrithik and father-in-law Manoj have been arrested. Efforts are on to arrest the others. Hrithik's father has a local business," a police officer said.

Responding to allegations by the victim's family regarding the marks found on Deepika's body, police said the matter was being investigated, and videography of the post-mortem examination would be conducted. "Relevant sections will be added as per the findings of the investigation," police said.

Speaking to reporters, Deepika's uncle Sunil Nagar alleged that around ₹1 crore was spent on the wedding by the bride's family, which included a Mahindra Scorpio vehicle, 35-40 tolas of gold, and cash given as dowry. He said that soon after the wedding in December 2024, Deepika's in-laws started demanding a Toyota Fortuner SUV and began harassing her.

According to the family, Hrithik is an LLB degree holder, while Deepika has completed a BA and B.Ed. Family members said problems started emerging within a few months of the marriage, but Deepika's parents chose not to approach the police, hoping the matter would be resolved amicably through discussions.



Metro Monday drew leaders support

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

It was 'Metro Monday' in the Capital. Delhi Metro recorded a strong response on Monday after the Delhi Government launched its "Metro Monday" campaign to encourage people to use public transport instead of private vehicles, conserving fuel and promoting sustainable mobility.

With passenger numbers expected to rise, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation introduced six additional trains and operated 24 extra trips across the network during the day. Officials said the arrangement would continue every Monday, and more services could be added if commuter demand increases further.

The initiative drew support from top political leaders and senior officials, many of whom travelled by Metro to promote the campaign publicly. Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh, Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, Labour Minister Kapil Mishra, Education Minister Ashish Sood, and Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh were among those who travelled through the Metro network on Monday.

BJP MP Manoj Tiwari and Delhi MLA Sanjay Goyal also joined the campaign by using Metro services during the day. Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav was also seen travelling by Metro while visiting the Capital.

The Delhi Government launched the "Metro Monday" initiative following recent developments in the Middle East and the national appeal for fuel conservation. The campaign urges residents to avoid using private vehicles on Mondays and shift



towards public transport systems such as Metro trains and buses.

Officials said the initiative is aimed at reducing fuel consumption, easing traffic congestion, and encouraging environmentally friendly travel in the national Capital. Delhi Metro stations across several busy corridors witnessed increased commuter movement during office hours. DMRC officials said the additional train trips were introduced to ensure smooth travel and prevent overcrowding.

According to the corporation, the move is part of a broader strategy to support sustainable urban mobility while offering commuters reliable and efficient public transport. Officials said the Delhi Metro network remains one of the most dependable transport systems in the city and can play an important role in reducing pollution caused by vehicular traffic.

The campaign also reflects the Delhi Government's recent emphasis on fuel conservation measures. Over the past few days, ministers and officials have been using Metro services, electric vehicles, and other public

transport options as part of awareness efforts.

Authorities have also encouraged work-from-home practices, carpooling, and reduced use of private vehicles to save fuel and cut emissions. Commuters welcomed the initiative and said wider public participation could help reduce traffic pressure on Delhi's roads, particularly during peak hours when congestion remains severe in several parts of the city.

Traffic experts have long argued that Delhi needs greater dependence on public transport, as it continues to struggle with pollution and traffic jams caused by the growing number of private vehicles.

DMRC officials said they would continue monitoring passenger flow in the coming weeks and make operational changes wherever required to ensure comfortable travel for commuters.

The Metro network currently carries millions of passengers daily across Delhi and adjoining regions. Officials believe campaigns such as "Metro Monday" can gradually encourage behavioural change among residents and strengthen public transport usage.

Jantar Mantar road: From INC HQ to library, a slice of Delhi history

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Jantar Mantar Road is more than just an elegant British-era bungalow in the heart of Delhi; it is steeped in history, having once served as the headquarters of the Indian National Congress (INC) and now also housing a library run by an old trust.

The two-storey structure on Jantar Mantar Road, known for its distinct architectural style, has witnessed numerous public protests and demonstrations over the decades. Its windows and slender columns create a facade that gives the building a graceful appearance.

A similar design can also be seen in the old Connaught Place building. The bungalow is in the news again, as last week the Delhi High Court sought the stand of the Centre and the Delhi government on a petition by the INC seeking execution of a sale deed in its favour for its former headquarters.

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav issued notices to the governments on the petition and the application for interim relief, seeking their replies to both. Even as senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the All

India Congress Committee, urged the court to pass an interim order to ensure that the premises are not allotted to someone else in the meantime, Justice Kaurav questioned the maintainability of the writ petition. "I doubt the maintainability. Therefore, if you have to press for interim relief, you have to satisfy that the petition is maintainable. See the Government's response. You perhaps have to file a civil suit. This seems to be to wriggle out of limitation," the judge orally said.

Singhvi said the party had been an allottee for decades, but the authorities have still not executed a sale deed in its favour. The Congress added that property records show part of the property has been with it since 1946, with an allotment in 1956.

The plea stated that in 1959, the party paid ₹6.1 lakh to the government for the sale, as well as annual payments toward additional premium and ground rent for change of use. Sale deed execution in Congress's favour was delayed by legal disputes, including tenant litigation and the party's 1969 split.

The rival Congress (O) faction, with other parties, defeated Indira Gandhi's Congress in the 1977 elec-



7, Jantar Mantar Road, an elegant British-era bungalow, earlier served as the headquarters of the INC and currently also houses a library run by an old trust in New Delhi on Monday

tions after the Emergency imposed in 1975 was lifted. In January 2025, the INC moved to its new headquarters, Indira Bhawan, at Kotla Marg, from the 24 Akbar Road address, where it had operated for 47 years.

Each floor of Indira Bhawan represents an era of Congress history. The older 7, Jantar

Mantar Road headquarters also served as the Janata Dal (United) party's central office for years. On its ground floor, the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Smarak Trust Library houses rare books and publications, including those associated with the Congress party. The bungalow has lost some of its old charm, with a

worn facade and a dusty grand staircase that belie its former architectural glory.

The property was granted to Sardar Dharam Singh in 1920 through a lease, which was later purchased by Nawab Abdul Hassan Khan, who left for Pakistan after partition. The central government later declared it evacuee property, according to available accounts. The petition stated that, in 2014, the Supreme Court ruled that, following the party's split, the petitioner was entitled to all property and funds existing before 1969. Consequently, numerous representations were made to the Delhi Government, which is responsible for managing the property, from 2017 onwards, to execute a sale deed, but to no avail.

Singhvi, during the hearing, contended, "I have repeatedly asked for execution of the conveyance deed, but there is no denial and no response. I have occupied the property for 70 years and possess all documents and payment records. The dispute is that the deed has not been executed, yet they are considering allotting it to someone else". The court has scheduled the next hearing for September 14.

Peak power demand soars to 7,542 MW in Capital



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The peak power demand in the national Capital soared to 7,542 megawatts, the highest so far this summer, as the day temperature rose to 43.4 degrees Celsius on Monday. Mercury is rising in the city with the progression of summer. The weather department has predicted the maximum temperature to rise further to 44 degrees Celsius on Tuesday.

Real-time data from the State Load Dispatch Centre in Delhi showed the

peak demand at 7,542 MW at 4.05 pm on Monday.

The peak demand on Sunday was 7,094 MW. This year, the peak power demand in Delhi is estimated to cross 9,000 MW. The highest peak demand last year was recorded at 8,442 MW on June 12. The all-time high in peak power demand in the capital was 8,656 MW, recorded on June 19, 2024.

Discoms say the rise in power demand in summer is pushed up primarily by enhanced use of coolers, air conditioners and refrigeration appliances.

Woman alleges harassment by roommate's guests, FIR filed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have registered a case after a woman accused her roommate's male guests and relatives of threatening, intimidating and harassing her at a rented accommodation in Dwarka, officials said on Monday.

The complaint was lodged by a woman who has been living with another woman in a one-bedroom rented flat in Dwarka since February this year. Police said the dispute escalated after the roommate's family members and male visitors allegedly began visiting the shared accommodation frequently.

According to the complaint, tensions had been building between the two women for some time over domestic issues, including disagreements related to food and visitors entering the room. Police said the complainant objected to male guests visiting the shared accommodation and had earlier conveyed her discomfort to her roommate. However, the situation allegedly worsened recently when the roommate called four men to the room and introduced them as her cousins.

The complainant alleged that the roommate's sister-in-law was also present inside the accommodation at the time. In her statement to police, the woman claimed that one of the male visitors forcefully entered the room and allegedly misbehaved with her. She further alleged that the visitors threatened and intimidated



her, creating an atmosphere of fear inside the house.

According to the complaint, the woman felt unsafe and was forced to leave the room out of fear during the confrontation. Police officials said no physical assault or manhandling was reported from either side during the incident. However, based on the allegations made by the complainant, an FIR has been registered under relevant legal provisions and further investigation has been initiated.

"A case has been registered under appropriate sections. The matter is being investigated. No physical manhandling was reported from either side," a police officer said.

Investigators are now examining the sequence of events and verifying the allegations made in the complaint. Statements of the people involved are also expected to be recorded as part of the inquiry.

IN FOCUS



A flock of migratory flamingos is seen at a pond in Navi Mumbai PTI

CBI arrests key accused in Rath murder case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

In a significant breakthrough in the politically sensitive murder case of Chandranath Rath, personal assistant to West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested the alleged main shooter, Rajkumar, from Muzaffarnagar in Uttar Pradesh.

The arrest was made in coordination with the Muzaffarnagar Police. CBI sources confirmed that Rajkumar is the primary accused in the contract killing of Rath, who was shot dead in broad daylight on May 6th near his residence in Madhyamgram, North 24 Parganas district. The agency has secured a transit remand for the accused and will produce him before the Special CBI Court in Kolkata on Tuesday.

This latest development comes nearly a week after the CBI formally took over the probe from the West Bengal Police's Special Investigation



Team (SIT) on May 12th. The central agency had constituted a seven-member SIT, led by a DIG-rank officer, to investigate the conspiracy, money trail, and possible masterminds behind the killing. Earlier, the state SIT had arrested three suspected contract killers, Mayank Raj Mishra, Vicky Maurya, and Raj Singh, identified as a sharpshooter, from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

The trio were produced before a court in Barasat and remanded to 13 days of police custody. Investigators had claimed the murder was a paid assassination, with reports suggesting payments ranging from ₹70 lakh to over ₹1 crore for the operation.

Rath, a former Air Force serviceman and a trusted aide to Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, was ambushed by motorcycle-borne assailants who forced his vehicle to stop before opening fire at close range. The incident occurred just two days after the results of the West Bengal Assembly elections were

declared, in which the BJP-led alliance came to power. The CBI's involvement has intensified scrutiny on the interstate links in the case, including the supply of weapons and the precise intelligence of Rath's movements. Forensic teams from the CBI and Central Forensic Science Laboratory (CFSL) had earlier visited the crime scene as part of the probe.

With Rajkumar's arrest, the focus now shifts to interrogating him and the other three accused to unravel the full conspiracy. Officials said the agency is probing organised crime angles and possible political motives. The case has drawn significant attention across political circles in West Bengal, with both the ruling dispensation and opposition parties closely monitoring the developments.

The investigation remains ongoing, and further arrests cannot be ruled out as the CBI continues to trace the money trail and identify the higher-ups involved in the alleged contract killing.

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PM urges peace in Ukraine, West Asia

Addressing a joint press briefing in Oslo, PM Modi highlighted the significance of the recently implemented Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement between India and the European Free Trade Association (EFTA), which includes Norway, Switzerland, Iceland, and Liechtenstein.

He said the agreement would serve as a blueprint for shared growth and prosperity between India and Norway. "This agreement sets a target of attracting investments totalling 100 billion dollars into India and creating one million jobs over the next fifteen years," the PM said.

The investment framework is expected to focus on renewable energy, digital innovation, maritime industries, advanced manufacturing, and sustainable infrastructure.

PM Modi also recalled postponing his earlier Norway visit following the terrorist attack in Pahalgam last year. He thanked Norway for standing firmly with India during that period.

"During that difficult period, Norway demonstrated the true spirit of friendship by standing firmly alongside India in the fight against terrorism," he said.

The PM further stressed that the world is currently facing instability and uncertainty, underlining the importance of diplomacy and peaceful dialogue in resolving geopolitical conflicts.

Norwegian Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre said the visit reflected the growing partnership between the two democracies and highlighted the importance of cooperation in an increasingly polarised global environment.

"Partnerships matter, especially between democracies that share common interests and abide by common rules in the global community," Støre said.

He added that both countries would sign several agreements aimed at deepening collaboration in trade, technology, energy transition, and innovation.

The leaders reaffirmed their commitment to expanding India-Europe relations, with both sides describing the evolving partnership as a key pillar for future economic growth and geopolitical stability.

New faces dominate VD Satheesan...

CMP leader John and IUML leaders N Shamsuddin, K M Shaji, P K Basheer and V E Abdul Gafoor are the other new faces in the Cabinet.

Congress leaders PC Vishnunadh, Roji M John, T Siddique and OJ Janeesh are also among the first-time ministers.

Satheesan's predecessor and Marxist veteran Pinarayi Vijayan, Left leaders, and BJP representatives also attended the ceremony.

As each Cabinet minister took oath, loud cheers rose from thousands of UDF workers and supporters present at the venue.

The Assembly elections to the 140-member House were held on 9 April, with results declared on May 4. The Congress-led UDF won 102 seats, the LDF secured 35, and the BJP won three.

Parliament storm over NEET

The panel, headed by Congress leader Digvijaya Singh, has summoned Vineet Joshi, Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, and NTA Chairperson Pradeep Kumar Joshi. In his notice submitted to Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan, Ramesh said that during a press conference on May 15 after the cancellation of the NEET-UG exam, Pradhan made some "derogatory" remarks against a parliamentary committee, which "reveal his contempt for Parliament". Ramesh said it is well established that any derogatory references to parliamentary committees or members of parliamentary committees constitute a "gross contempt" of such committees, which in turn constitutes contempt of the House.

Latur coaching centre founder arrested...

They believe this bypassed digital trails. CBI officials say they recovered a leaked question set on his phone dated April 23. That was a full 10 days before the May 3 exam. The agency alleges he actively participated in leaking and circulating the paper. Searches at RCC's Shrivnagar office in Latur stretched into Sunday evening.

A complaint filed in the Latur police station alleged that 42 chemistry questions from an RCC mock test, circulated as 'Guess Papers', were carbon-copy identical to the actual NEET-UG paper. A viral video shows Motegaonkar himself

asking students after the exam how many of the institute's mock questions had appeared on it. The video only added fuel to the fire. "This wasn't coaching. This was cheating at scale," one parent told the CBI team.

Opposition parties, including Congress, have seized on the scandal. They staged protests in Latur and demanded the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. They called repeated leaks under the current regime, yet the CBI's probe points squarely at the Latur coaching nexus and alleged NTA insiders, not political patronage.

SC flags concerns over Umar Khalid bail ruling...

The KA Najeeb case recognised long delay in trial as a ground for bail in cases under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and can override the statutory restrictions on bail under Section 43D(5) of the Act.

"The judgment in the Gulfisha Fatima case would have us believe that Najeeb is only a narrow and exceptional departure from Section 43-D(5) justified in extreme factual situations. It is this hollowing out of the import of the observations in the Najeeb case that we are concerned with," the bench said.

"It is a constitutional principle flowing from Articles 21 and 22 of the Constitution and the presumption of innocence, which is the cornerstone of any civilised society governed by the rule of law. Statutes may undoubtedly calibrate the manner in which that principle is applied, particularly in cases involving national security or terrorist offences for which the UAP Act is meant, but those cannot altogether invert the constitutional relationship between liberty and detention," the bench said.

The top court said that the statutory embargo of Section 43-D(5) of the UAPA, which outlines stringent bail restrictions, must remain a circumscribed restriction that operates subject to the guarantee of Articles 21 and 22 of the Constitution.

"Therefore, we have no manner of doubt in stating that even under the UAP Act, 'bail is the rule and jail is the exception'; of course, in an appropriate case, bail can be denied having regard to the facts of that particular case," the bench said. It also disapproved the judgment of the two-judge bench delivered in 2024 in the Gurwinder Singh vs Union of India case for not applying the judgement passed in the KA Najeeb case.

The SC made it clear that its judgement in the Najeeb case is a binding law that cannot be diluted, circumvented or disregarded by trial courts, high courts or even by benches of a lower strength of the top court.

The Najeeb case is a landmark Supreme Court ruling delivered in 2021 regarding bail under the UAPA. "In our view, the decision in the Gurwinder case, inasmuch as it refuses to be bound by Najeeb, is difficult to be followed by us as a matter of precedent. It is plain that a judgment rendered by a bench of lesser strength is bound by the law declared by a bench of greater strength," the bench noted.

Syed Iftikhar Andrabi had challenged an order passed by the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, which dismissed his bail plea, saying the scrutiny of cellphone records indicated that he had been in touch with terror operatives across the border. Narrating the sequence of events leading to the apprehension of the accused, the NIA had said that on June 11, 2020, police intercepted a car belonging to Abdul Momin Peer at Kairo Bridge, Handwara. During a search, Rs 20.01 lakh in cash and 2 kg of heroin were seized, and Peer was arrested.

Later, on his disclosure, the police arrested Andrabi and Islam-UI-Haq Peer.

Investigation revealed that the accused were allegedly involved in cross-border smuggling and supply of heroin in Jammu and Kashmir and other parts of the country after procuring the same from their associates in Pakistan, the chargesheet said. Andrabi and Abdul Momin Peer had visited Pakistan several times during 2016-17 to meet the operatives of terrorist organisations, including Lashkar-e-Taiba and Hizbul Mujahideen, it said, adding that the amount generated from the sale of heroin was used by the accused to further the terrorist activities of Lashkar-e-Taiba.

Delhi drug squad faces heat

CBI investigators called the Dwarka ANC under Yadav a "predatory extortion machine." The unit is accused of targeting innocent people, business owners, and small-time drug offenders. Officers are said to have planted cannabis, filed or threatened false NDPS cases, and demanded settlements as high as ₹50 lakh per case. In exchange,

the group allegedly protected real drug dealers, including foreign networks. The officers are accused of taking advantage of the wide powers given for narcotics raids, which have little immediate oversight.

CBI seized ₹48.9 lakh in unexplained cash from the ANC office, most of it found in Yadav's workspace and not accounted for. There were transactions, benami properties, and assets worth over ₹100 crore. This is far in excess of Yadav's known sources of income. CBI told the court that there were multiple phone calls between Yadav and other officers in the unit, at the exact time the ₹48.9 lakh cash was being recovered during the office raid. This contradicts any claim of non-involvement.

At first, phone records linked Yadav to the raid and the bribe talks. Later, a direct account described the drug planting and a phone negotiation with 'Subhash' during the incident. Now, the CBI is reviewing bank accounts, digital records, and past Dwarka ANC cases to identify similar extortion schemes.

During questioning, Inspector Yadav reportedly named three senior IPS officers from the AGMUT cadre. He claimed they were involved, knew about the racket, or gave protection. One of these officers is now working with the CBI, which is leading the investigation. This situation raises concerns about possible conflicts of interest and the need for safeguards.

The agency is examining whether these officers had any role in providing protection or influencing postings related to the narcotics cell. The CBI is also probing if these officers benefited from the corruption or helped the ₹100-crore network.

CBI officials are tracking the full money trail and hidden assets. They are also looking into links with drug syndicates that the unit may have protected, questioning more people, and examining Yadav's shady network.

The case has already caused strong reactions among top officials. The CBI has sent a detailed report to the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), which oversees Delhi Police. This has led to internal changes, including transfers of senior officers.

Inspector Yadav and HC Ajay have been remanded in CBI custody at various stages, and courts are monitoring developments closely. The CBI has not yet commented publicly on the senior IPS allegations, other than confirming that the inquiry is ongoing.

"This is not the first time questions have been raised about corruption in narcotics enforcement, but the scale here, and the alleged reach into senior ranks, has rattled the establishment. Whether the Dwarka episode proves to be an isolated unit-level racket or points to deeper systemic issues", a senior cop said.

Delhi CM Rekha Gupta takes metro to push...

On the other hand, travelling in DTC's electric buses is comfortable, safe, and environmentally friendly."

Rekha Gupta added that the Delhi Government is leading by example through initiatives such as a two-day work-from-home policy, reduced use of Government vehicles, increased online meetings, and prioritising public transport.

Cabinet ministers Ashish Sood, Manjinder Singh Sirsa, Kapil Mishra, Pankaj Singh also took the metro to reach their destinations.

Transport Minister Pankaj Singh travelled by Delhi Metro to Ram Krishna Ashram Marg station. Sirsa also used the metro to reach the Delhi Secretariat. Mishra travelled by Metro and feeder bus to the Delhi Secretariat.

Minister for Social Welfare, SC/ST/OBC Welfare, Cooperatives, and Elections, Ravinder Indraj Singh, travelled to the Delhi Secretariat by Metro and feeder bus.

BJP MP Manoj Tiwari along with NDMC Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal travelled through public transport. Chahal and Tiwari first travelled in a shared e-Rickshaw to promote clean and convenient last-mile connectivity and thereafter boarded the Delhi Metro from Sewa Teerth to Rajiv Chowk Metro Station.

West Bengal ends religion-based clergy aid

In March, the previous Mamata Banerjee Government increased the honorarium for religious leaders by ₹500. Imams of registered mosques received ₹3,000 per month, while muezins and purohits received ₹2,000 per month. The cabinet has approved the 'Annapurna' scheme, which will give women in West Bengal ₹3,000 per month from June 1. The cabinet also gave in-principle approval for free travel for women on state-run buses.

Addressing a press conference after the second cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister

Suwendu Adhikari, Paul announced the scrapping of the existing state OBC list. This decision is based on a Calcutta High Court judgment.

The minister also announced that the cabinet has approved the constitution of the Seventh State Pay Commission to revise the salary structure of Government employees.

She, however, confirmed that the issue of granting increased dearness allowance (DA) to state employees was not on the agenda of Monday's meeting.

"The cabinet gave its in-principle nod to the 'Annapurna' scheme of ₹3,000 monthly assistance to women from June 1. Those currently receiving assistance under the previous Government's Lakshmir Bhandar scheme will automatically be eligible for the Annapurna Yojana. There is no need to reapply. Money will be sent through direct bank transfer," Paul said.

The Government will launch a web portal to help new applicants who have not yet received assistance.

"Women who applied for citizenship under the CAA and those who approached the tribunals for inclusion of names in voter rolls will also be entitled to receive the Annapurna scheme benefit," the minister clarified.

Paul said the cabinet approved a proposal allowing women to travel for free on Government-run buses from June 1.

The cabinet does not plan to increase the number of buses at this time. The State Pay Commission was to revise the salaries of its employees, stating that the scope of the pay hike would also extend to staff of statutory entities such as civic bodies and local bodies, education boards, and those working in state-run educational institutions.

"The details of the commission's set-up will be duly notified," she said, without specifying its date of implementation.

In his pre-election campaigns, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had pledged that the new pay commission would be implemented within 45 days of the BJP Government's formation in Bengal. Announcing yet another significant cabinet decision, Paul said that the new BJP Government would cancel the state's existing OBC list. This move is in accordance with a 2024 Calcutta High Court judgment.

Paul said the cabinet decided to revise and cancel the current OBC list and quota percentages as per the May 22, 2024, Calcutta High Court judgment.

The minister announced that the state will form a panel to determine eligibility for the OBC quota. The list's controversy centres on the inclusion of 77 communities. Of these, 75 are Muslim. Their inclusion into the state's Other Backwards Classes (OBC) list was initiated during the TMC regime. The decision sparked major political and legal battles. The Calcutta High Court cancelled the notice and invalidated nearly 5 lakh caste certificates issued since 2010.

ED arrests AAP leader over alleged bank fraud

Singla, AAP's Goa co-in-charge and a former candidate from Delhi's Vishwas Nagar, was taken into custody after several hours of questioning.

The arrest has triggered a sharp political slugest. AAP's Leader of Opposition in Delhi, Atishi accused the BJP of misusing Central agencies to target the party ahead of the Goa polls scheduled for next year, where AAP claims rising support. "With Aam Aadmi Party's popularity growing in Goa, BJP's loyal foot-soldier, ED, has been sent here as well," Atishi posted on X. She alleged the raids were aimed at intimidating workers and seizing organisational data. AAP supporters gathered outside Singla's residence in Delhi, raising slogans against the BJP and the ED.

Singla's arrest comes amid heightened scrutiny by central agencies of AAP leaders. The party has repeatedly described such actions as politically motivated "vendetta politics." This is especially the case in States where AAP challenges the BJP.

The case involves allegations that, between May 2023 and July 2025, Singla and associates submitted forged documents to public sector banks to secure large loans, which were allegedly diverted for personal use. Singla first came under ED scrutiny in 2024 as part of this ongoing investigation.

The ED has not yet released a detailed statement on the exact quantum of the alleged fraud or the full list of accused. Sources indicated that the money-laundering case directly follows from the bank fraud probe. It is an ongoing investigation, and more arrests are likely in this case, an ED official said.

BJP leaders welcomed the arrest. Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva said it exposed tax evasion, loan fraud, and the purchase of property using black money linked to the Aam Aadmi Party and Arvind Kejriwal. BJP MLA Om Prakash

Sharma said courts, the ED, and CBI are holding the party accountable for alleged corruption.

As Singla is produced before a court for remand, the episode is likely to intensify the ongoing war of words between AAP and the BJP. Assembly elections are approaching in several states, including Goa. Both sides are expected to frame the arrest as either a victory for accountability or an abuse of power.

US draws curtain on Adani investigations

Court filings showed Gautam Adani agreed to pay \$6 million and Sagar Adani \$12 million, without admitting or denying wrongdoing.

Thereafter, the US Treasury Department's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) settled allegations of the Adani Group violating US sanctions on Iran in LPG imports. This followed the Indian conglomerate agreeing to pay \$275 million while extending "extensive cooperation" with the investigation and making "proactive" disclosures. Now, the US prosecutors at the Eastern District of New York dropped all charges against Gautam Adani and his nephew Sagar Adani.

In a filing before the court, the US Department of Justice requested for dismissal of the indictment against the Adanis with prejudice.

"The Department of Justice has reviewed this case and has decided, in its prosecutorial discretion, not to devote further resources to these criminal charges against individual defendants," it said. Thereafter, the court ordered that the indictment against Adani and others "be dismissed with prejudice".

The closure marks a dramatic turn in a case that had threatened to disrupt the Adani Group's global expansion plans. The SEC and DOJ cases, filed in late 2024, alleged the Adanis orchestrated a USD 265 million bribery scheme involving Indian officials to secure solar power contracts and concealed the arrangement from US investors and lenders while raising capital.

The dismissal was "with prejudice", preventing the case from being reopened.

Such dismissals are uncommon in US criminal proceedings and typically reflect a determination that pursuing the case is no longer warranted after extensive review.

The case turned in Adani's favour after prosecutors found no clear US linkages and insufficient evidence to sustain the allegations, according to people familiar with matter. The anticipated decision follows months of aggressive engagement between US prosecutors and a formidable legal team assembled by the Adanis.

Five American legal counsel from Sullivan & Cromwell, alongside Nixon Peabody, Hecker Fink, Norton Rose Fulbright and Bracewell, made a series of submissions and presentations to US authorities as part of the review process. The review failed to produce findings capable of sustaining charges against Gautam and Sagar Adani, prompting the DOJ to move towards dismissal.

In submissions disclosed publicly on April 7, 2026, before the United States District Court for the Eastern District of New York, Adani's lawyers mounted a forceful challenge to the US SEC's fraud-related proceedings, calling them an "impermissibly extraterritorial application" of US securities laws. The defence argued the case involved, "Indian Defendants, an Indian issuer", securities not traded on US exchanges and alleged conduct occurring "exclusively in India".

The filings stated the SEC "lacked necessary jurisdiction", failed to establish actionable misstatements and could not tie either defendant to the bond offering. The lawyers asserted the SEC had "recast" unviabl anti-bribery allegations into securities fraud claims. The submissions noted there were "no investor losses", all bond obligations were honoured and Gautam Adani "did not authorise the issuance of the bonds".

The case had faced mounting scrutiny from legal experts over whether prosecutors had stretched securities laws to pursue conduct centred overseas.

Gautam Adani, Sagar Adani and Vneet Jaan were charged only under securities and wire fraud statutes (counts 2, 3 and 4). They were not named in the more serious Foreign Corrupt Practices Act bribery charge or obstruction-related count (counts 1 and 5), which prosecutors brought against other defendants in the wider case.

The Adani Group has consistently rejected the allegations as meritless, defending its governance and compliance standards while pledging to contest the proceedings through legal channels. That distinction, along with no US linkages, increasingly molded criticism of the government's legal approach. Former SEC commissioner Laura Unger argued that authorities had effectively attempted to predicate a securities fraud case on allegations of bribery that had neither been adjudicated nor formally pursued in India.

Parliamentary panel to review NEET paper leak, NTA reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has decided to review the implementation of reforms in the National Testing Agency (NTA) as well as the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case and has summoned NTA Chairperson Pradeep Kumar Joshi and other bureaucrats for deliberations.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports will seek the views of top education ministry bureaucrats on the alleged paper leak and reforms of NTA, which holds centralised admission tests to various undergraduate courses, on May 21, a Rajya Sabha notice said.

The agenda includes a review of the implementation of the K Radhakrishnan Committee report on NTA



reforms and an update on the investigation into the alleged NEET-UG paper leak case.

The committee, headed by Congress leader Digvijaya Singh, has summoned the Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, Vineet Joshi, and NTA Chairperson Pradeep Kumar Joshi for deliberations.

The NTA cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Exam

(Undergraduate) held on May 3 amid allegations of irregularities. Nearly 23 lakh candidates had registered for the test, which was administered by the NTA across the country.

According to the NTA, information regarding alleged malpractice was received on the evening of May 7, four days after the exam was held.

Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Friday announced that the

NEET-UG re-examination would be held on June 21. He said the medical entrance exam would be computer-based from next year.

The panel will also deliberate on the impact of Artificial Intelligence (AI) on education and strategies to enhance students' employability. Representatives from Anthropic India, Pratham, IIT Kanpur, Infosys and IIT Madras are among those summoned for the discussions.

In a separate session, the committee will hold discussions with the vice-chancellor of Aligarh Muslim University (AMU) and the chairperson of the National Commission for Minority Educational Institutions (NCMEI) on issues related to institutions, including implementation of reservations, vacancies and the National Education Policy (NEP).

BJP hails PM Modi's foreign tour as unprecedented

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the UAE, the Netherlands and Sweden has proved to be "unprecedented" from strategic, economic and cultural perspectives as the pacts signed with these countries will strengthen India's energy security and boost its economy with foreign investment.

Speaking to reporters at the BJP headquarters, BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi also hailed the bestowing of the 'Royal Order of the Polar Star, Degree Commander Grand Cross', one of Sweden's highest civilian honours, on Prime Minister Modi, calling it a "moment of pride" for every



BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi

Indian. This is not merely an honour for Modi as an individual, it stands as a symbol that the PM is establishing the potential and excellence of 1.40 crore Indians on the global stage, he said. With this, the prime minister has been conferred with 31 international awards during his tenure so far, Trivedi said.

Prime Minister Modi was in

Norway on Monday and held talks with his Norwegian counterpart Jonas Gahr Store on trade and investment, green technology, blue economy, and other key areas.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi is on an extremely important foreign tour to protect the interests of the people of India. His foreign tour has so far proved to be

unprecedented and historic from strategic, economic and cultural perspectives," Trivedi said.

Highlighting the key takeaways from Modi's visit to the three countries, the BJP Rajya Sabha MP said the pacts signed with these countries will help India strengthen its energy security and boost its economy with foreign direct investment (FDI).

"The prime minister finds some of the other solutions to problems despite all the challenges," Trivedi said.

The BJP leader also attacked Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his foreign trips, saying the suspicion around his trips abroad is deepening in the minds of the people, as he has yet to disclose who has been funding his visits.

Rajnath Singh embarks on four-day visit to Vietnam, South Korea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday embarked on a four-day visit to Vietnam and South Korea to explore ways to shore up strategic defence cooperation, including joint production of military hardware.

Before leaving for

tion in the South China Sea, a region that has witnessed increasing Chinese military muscle-flexing.

There have been growing concerns over China's sweeping claims of sovereignty over all of the South China Sea, a huge source of hydrocarbons.

Several countries in the region, including Vietnam, the Philippines and Brunei,



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh is welcomed upon his arrival at the airport during an official visit to Vietnam in Hanoi

States Focus



PM LAUDS SATHEESAN ON TAKING OATH AS KERALA CM

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday congratulated VD Satheesan on taking oath as the Chief Minister of Kerala and assured all possible help from the Central Government in fulfilling people's aspirations.

Satheesan, who led the Congress-led UDF back to power in the State after a decade by decimating the Left front, took oath as Kerala Chief Minister on Monday.

"Congratulations to Shri VD Satheesan Ji on taking oath as the Chief Minister of Keralam. My best wishes for his tenure. The Central Government assures all possible support for the newly formed Keralam Government in fulfilling the aspirations of the people," Modi said in a post on social media.



SPECIAL TRAINS ANNOUNCED FOR GANGA DUSSEHRA MELA

Northern Railway has announced the operation of unreserved special trains to accommodate the anticipated surge of passengers travelling for the upcoming Ganga Dussehra Mela in Haridwar. The special trains will operate on two key routes, starting with the Haridwar Junction - Delhi-Shahdara Junction unreserved Mela Special (Train number 04308/04307), which will run on May 25, 2026 and May 26, 2026. Additionally, the Haridwar Junction - Lucknow Junction unreserved Mela Special (Train number 04302/04301) will also be pressed into service.

India on alert after Ebola outbreak in Africa

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ebola outbreak in parts of Africa has once again raised global public health concerns, with Indian authorities keeping a close watch on the evolving situation and health experts stressing the importance of surveillance to prevent its possible importation into the country.

The World Health Organisation (WHO) has declared the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) and Uganda a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) after more than 300 suspected cases, and nearly 90 deaths were reported.

Indian health ministry officials said the National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC) is closely monitoring developments, while a review meeting was also held to assess India's preparedness, screening mechanisms and response strategy in case of any suspected case being detected in the country.

Ebola is a severe and often fatal illness caused by the Ebola virus, which spreads through direct contact with the blood, body fluids or tissues of infected people or animals.

The symptoms of Ebola disease can be sudden and include fever, fatigue, malaise, muscle pain,



headache and sore throat. These are followed by vomiting, diarrhoea, abdominal pain, rash, and symptoms of impaired kidney and liver functions.

While there is currently no Ebola outbreak in India, experts said international travel and global connectivity mean that countries must remain vigilant against infectious disease threats.

India reported its only known Ebola case in November 2014, when a 26-year-old man who had travelled from Liberia tested positive for the virus in Delhi. Health authorities had then isolated the patient and carried out extensive contact tracing, preventing any further spread, according to Government sources.

The WHO had earlier declared Ebola outbreaks as a PHEIC in 2014 during the massive West Africa outbreak that killed more than 11,000 people, and in 2019 during

the outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo. The latest declaration marks the third time Ebola has triggered the WHO's highest level of global health alert.

The disease has previously caused major outbreaks in several African nations, with fatality rates ranging from 25 to 90 per cent, depending on the strain and healthcare response.

Dr Sanjay Rai, Professor at the Department of Community Medicine, AIIMS Delhi, said India's risk at present remains low.

"India has robust airport screening systems and disease surveillance mechanisms compared to earlier years. However, any outbreak anywhere in the world is a reminder that infectious diseases do not respect borders. Travellers coming from affected countries need close monitoring," Dr Rai said.

ED attaches ₹700 cr assets of Dawood aide Iqbal Mirchi

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has provisionally attached assets worth ₹700.27 crore belonging to the late Iqbal Mohammad Memon (Iqbal Mirchi) and his family. The attached assets include three sea-facing properties in Mumbai's Worli neighbourhood: Rabia Mansion, Marium Lodge, and Sea View, collectively valued at approximately ₹497 crore.

Additionally, overseas assets in Dubai worth ₹203.27 crore have been frozen under the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act (FEOA). The

agency announced the action on Monday, noting that it is one of the largest attachments in recent years involving the network of global terrorist Dawood Ibrahim's associate.

According to the ED, the case is based on multiple FIRs filed by the Mumbai Police against Mirchi under the IPC, the Arms Act, TADA, and the NDPS Act. The agency alleges that Mirchi, who fled to the UK in the 1990s, operated a criminal enterprise involving drug trafficking, extortion, and illegal arms dealing.

A senior ED official stated, "The investigation has estab-



lished a clear money trail. Proceeds generated from these organised criminal activities were systematically layered and integrated through the purchase and control of prime real estate in India and abroad. These were often masked behind family members, close associates and corporate entities." The three Worli properties

NCB cracks down on international Captagon syndicate

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Dehradun/New Delhi

In a major operation called RAZEPILL, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) shut down an illegal factory making Captagon. This amphetamine-based drug, often called the 'jihadi Drug', is reportedly used by militants in conflict areas. The factory was in Dehradun, Uttarakhand. This raid is India's first big seizure of Captagon. Authorities found about 227.7 kg of Captagon tablets and powder, worth



around ₹182 crore.

After receiving a tip, NCB teams went to a house in Delhi's Neb Sarai and arrested a Syrian national. He was a key member of an international drug traffick-

ing group, had overstayed his tourist visa, and was found with a large amount of Captagon. During questioning, he revealed that Captagon was illegally made in November 2025 at

are central to the investigation. The ED claims these were acquired in 1986 through Rockside Enterprises for ₹6.5 lakh and registered under the Sir Mohammad Yusuf Trust. However, investigators have found evidence that actual ownership and control remained with Mirchi and his immediate family. The trust's name remained on paper for decades. "This is a classic case of benami structuring and the use of trusts to perpetuate criminal wealth," the official added.

"Even after Mirchi's death, the economic benefits continued to flow to his family, which is why the attach-

ment has been effected against them as well." Mirchi was Dawood Ibrahim's associate in international operations and was accused of the 1993 Mumbai serial blasts that killed over 250 people. Agencies have maintained that he played a key role in financing and facilitating the conspiracy from abroad. Mirchi evaded arrest for years, living in London until his death from a heart attack on August 14, 2013, at age 63. Investigations have continued to focus on his extensive real estate portfolio, much of which is located in premium areas of Mumbai and overseas.

CITU backs AIESL workers' 5-day mass sit-in

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) on Monday expressed its full solidarity with the ongoing country-wide mass sit-in by workers of Air India Engineering Services Limited (AIESL), a public sector undertaking under the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

The workers have been staging a sit-in for the past five days in front of the major Maintenance, Repair, and Overhaul (MRO) facilities in Delhi, Chennai, Mumbai, Kolkata and Nagpur, protesting against what they termed as the brazenly anti-worker



policies of the management.

In a statement issued by CITU President Sudip Dutta, the trade union highlighted that more than 1,100 fixed-term employees are directly affected by a highly discriminatory employment regime. CITU pointed out that while Government

guidelines mandate that fixed-term workers receive wages and benefits on par with regular employees, fixed-term staff at AIESL — ranging from engineers to helpers — are being paid less than one-third of the salaries received by their regular counterparts.

Furthermore, despite serving continuously for 8 to 12 years, these workers are allegedly denied regular increments, social security benefits, medical facilities and career progression.

CITU also raised serious alarms regarding the exploitative working conditions, noting that engineers and technicians responsible for critical aircraft safety are forced to work 12 to 14 hours a day. They are reportedly compensated at a meagre overtime rate of around ₹85 per hour, in blatant violation of labour provisions that mandate double the ordinary wage rate for overtime.

AIKS protests against fertiliser price hike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) on Monday registered a strong protest against the Central Government's failure to curb the sharp surge in market prices of fertilisers. It demanded immediate intervention to prevent hoarding, artificial scarcity, and rampant black marketing.

In a joint statement issued by AIKS President Ashok Dhawale and General Secretary Vijoo Krishnan, the farmers' body warned that inadequate fertiliser stocks would drastically diminish upcoming harvest yields, thereby escalating rural eco-



nomical distress and food inflation across the country.

According to the AIKS, the retail price of Muriate of Potash (MOP) has been hiked to the range of ₹1,800-2,000 per bag compared to ₹1,500 last season, marking a 20 to 33 per cent surge in major agricultural hubs like Kerala's

Kuttanad, Kottayam, and Palakkad. Similarly, the price of Factomfos has shot up to ₹1,750-1,900 from ₹1,425. Farmers in several major agrarian States, including Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, and Haryana, are facing severe

scarcity, indirect price hikes, and illegal overcharging.

The AIKS stated that while official prices remain unchanged on paper, local traders and private dealers are engaging in widespread retail malpractice and artificial hoarding due to supply disruptions in West Asia. It heavily criticised the Modi regime for slashing fertiliser subsidies by 8.4 per cent in this year's budget estimates.

The statement also slammed Central Government's foreign policy, accusing it of "succumbing to US imperialism" and damaging India's energy, fuel, and fertiliser security under pressure from the Trump administration.

■ States Focus ■



TN CM JOSEPH VIJAY TO MEET PM MODI IN DELHI ON MAY 22

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay is expected to visit the national Capital on May 22 to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi, a source said on Monday. During his three-day maiden trip as Chief Minister, Vijay is also expected to meet External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and raise the frequent attacks on Tamil Nadu fishermen by the Sri Lankan coast guard, with him, the source added. He is likely to meet Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. During the meeting, he would make a presentation requesting central aid for numerous development issues. (PTI)



AIADMK MLA A Anbalagan is greeted by CM N Rangaswamy, after taking charge as the pro-tem speaker of the 16th Puducherry Legislative Assembly in the presence of Lieutenant Governor of Puducherry Kuniyil Kailashnathan in Puducherry on Monday (PTI)

A ANBALAGAN TAKES OATH AS PUDUCHERRY PRO TEM SPEAKER

AIADMK legislator A Anbalagan was sworn in as pro tem speaker of the Puducherry Assembly during a brief ceremony held in Lok Niwas in Puducherry on Monday. Lt Governor K Kailashnathan administered the oath to Anbalagan in Tamil. Chief Minister N Rangasamy, BJP leader A Namassivayam, another Minister Malladi Krishna Rao (AINRC) from Yanam, legislators belonging to different political parties, and Chief Secretary Sharat Chauhan were among those who greeted Anbalagan after he took oath as pro tem speaker. According to official sources, Anbalagan would administer the oath of office to all the newly elected legislators, officially inducting them as members of the 16th Assembly of Puducherry on the floor of the House on May 20. (PTI)

HD Deve Gowda turns 94, vows to fight for people’s cause

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Former Prime Minister HD Deve Gowda, who celebrated his 94th birthday on Monday, said he wants to fight for the cause of the people as long as possible, moving around in his wheelchair. The JD(S) patriarch also expressed confidence that his party will not have any alliance issues with the BJP ahead of the 2028 Assembly polls, as he shares a good relationship

with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah. “I have a firm resolve to fight for the people’s cause for as many more days as possible. I will not sit at home saying that I have completed 93 years. I will move around in the wheelchair,” Gowda said. Speaking to reporters, he said, “I have been fighting throughout my 68-year political life. I’m not worried about how much people recognise it, but fighting for the cause of the people

is something that is before me; I will do my job.” Gowda said he received a message from PM Modi on his birthday from Sweden, while Home Minister Shah and senior BJP leader BS Yediyurappa greeted him over the phone. Similarly, several political leaders, including BJP national President Nitin Nabin, greeted him on the occasion. Asked about the 2028 Karnataka Assembly polls, he said, JD(S) as a regional party is a minor partner in



Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy greets his father and Janata Dal (Secular) president HD Deve Gowda on his birthday in Bengaluru (PTI)

the NDA. “Since I have a good relationship with Modi and Shah, I have strong confidence that there won’t be issues (in the alliance), and any issues that arise

Land grab accused Sona Pappu appears before ED



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

A man, identified as Sona Pappu, allegedly involved in land grabbing and extortion, appeared before the Enforcement Directorate in Kolkata on Monday in connection with its probe into a money laundering case, an official said. Biswajit Poddar, alias Sona Pappu, had been absconding since the central agency started an investigation into land grabbing, extortion and financial fraud charges. He appeared before the ED sleuths this morning after the agency arrested Kolkata Police Deputy Commissioner Santanu Sinha Biswas for his alleged involvement in “offences linked to Sona Pappu”, an official said. Denying any link to alleged land grabbing, he claimed that there is no complaint against him at any police station. “I have come here as the ED issued a summons against me. I do not know Santanu Sinha Biswas,” he said as he entered the central agency’s Kolkata office.

BJP hits at Congress as Satheesan takes oath as Kerala CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday slammed the Congress over VD Satheesan being sworn in as the Kerala chief minister, alleging the party has “surrendered to Islamists” and is functioning under pressure from the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) and Jamaat-e-Islami. Satheesan on Monday took oath as Kerala’s chief minister, with

Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administering the oath of office to the Congress Legislature Party leader in Thiruvananthapuram. BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged the Congress leadership has ignored the will of its MLAs while selecting the chief ministerial candidate. In a post on social media, Poonawalla said, “Congrats to the first CM of Jamaat & IUML Shri VD Satheeshan.” IUML is the second-

largest constituent of the Congress-led UDF coalition in Kerala.

Sharing a video statement along with the post, the BJP leader alleged that the Congress high command has “capitulated” to the demands of the Muslim League and Jamaat-e-Islami for “vote-bank politics”. “As soon as Satheeshan has been picked by the Congress party under pressure from the Muslim League and Jamaat, the Muslim League is showing its true colours,” he claimed.



Son of absconding TMC MLA held with weapons in West Bengal



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Police have arrested the son of “absconding” TMC MLA Dilip Mondal, along with five others, for allegedly possessing firearms from the Bakkhali-Fraserganj area of West Bengal, a senior officer said on Monday. A joint team of the West Bengal Police and Diamond Harbour district police apprehended them late on Sunday, he said. “Arghya Mondal and the others were found to be in

possession of firearms. Two pistols and six mobile phones were seized during the operation,” the officer said. All the accused were brought to the Diamond Harbour police station for questioning, he said. Arghya Mondal was also allegedly threatening BJP workers and supporters, the officer said. Trinamool Congress MLA Dilip Mondal, who represents the Bishnupur constituency, is “absconding” and a search is underway to trace him, police said.

Shah opens 1st security camp-turned-public service centre

NEELABH SRIVASTAVA
■ Jagdalpur

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday inaugurated the first security camp-turned-public service centre in a remote village in Bastar district of Chhattisgarh, heralding a new development chapter in the State recently declared Naxal violence-free after decades of extremism. The minister said 70 out of the total 196 security forces camps located in the erstwhile Left Wing Extremism (LWE) affected areas of the State will be transformed into ‘Seva camps’ (public service centres) over the next one-and-a-half years. Officials said that the event heralds the launch of the Bastar 2.0 road map, where security camps will be “repurposed” for public welfare utility works, an essential plan of action of the Union and State Government to ensure Maoism never returns to these areas due to a lack of development.

Shah is on a three-day visit to the central Indian State, his first after the Union Government declared the end of LWE from the country in March. He reached the State Capital Raipur on Sunday night, over 300 km from here. The minister opened the ‘Jan Suvidha Kendra’ (public service centre) co-located inside the ‘Bravo’ company campus of the CRPF’s 80th battalion in Netanar village. The Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) established the camp in 2013 as an operations base, and it has now shared a part of this facility for the creation of the service centre. “This is a revolutionary event that has taken place today with the inauguration of this camp in the name of Shaheed Veer (martyr) Gundadthur of this region. Once, six policemen were killed at this place, and hospitals and schools were destroyed by the Naxalites. “I promise we will bring the State Government sitting in



Union Home Minister Amit Shah along with Speaker of the Chhattisgarh Legislative Assembly Dr Raman Singh and CM Vishnu Deo Sai flags off 400 new vehicles for the ‘CG Dial 112’ emergency response service in Raipur, Chhattisgarh on Monday (PTI)

Raipur to your doorstep within the next one-and-a-half years,” Shah said. Out of the 196 security camps in this region, 70 will be transformed as ‘Seva camps’ in the next one-and-a-half years, he said. Shah said the National Institute of Design (NID) has been tasked to prepare a model for these ‘Seva camps’,

which will not only provide all kinds of Government services to the public but also help in skilling locals for self-employment. He added that a cooperative society model for dairy and minor forest produce will be developed for the tribals of the Bastar region, which comprises seven districts, including the district

named Bastar itself. Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai said during the event that Shah has ensured that development is ushered in the Bastar region with the end of about four decades of violent Naxalism. Deputy CM and Home Minister of Chhattisgarh Vijay Sharma was also present during the event. A senior State Government officer said the earmarked camps of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) in Chhattisgarh are being gradually “repurposed” and transformed from being a base for armed operations to becoming platforms of public service by the State Government in coordination with the Union Home Ministry. A ‘Jan Suvidha Kendra’ will act like a Common Service Centre (CSC) for people to provide services such as Aadhaar updates, banking facilities, applications for income, caste and domicile certificates, ration card services, Ayushman Bharat cards, e-Shram registration, electricity bill payment, online applications, railway and bus ticket booking, he said. State Government and Union Home Ministry officials added that the centres will also train locals in various livelihood skills with the help of self-help groups (SHGs). “The Jan Suvidha Kendra initiative is significant for villages where people have to travel long distances for availing the benefits of basic Government schemes or services,” a second State Government officer said. Pinki Naag, a woman from Netanar village, said that she began training for stitching at the service centre on May 13, and she aims to earn ₹6,000 per month through this skill. “The security camps that once strategised anti-Naxal operations will soon be synonymous with portals of development. The Netanar camp will show the way forward,” Neetu Sethia, who works with a local SHG, said after the inauguration. (PTI)



Maharashtra Government approves ₹993 crore for 6 pilgrimage, heritage sites

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday directed officials to complete development works at pilgrimage centres and historical sites in time and provide high-quality facilities, including modern amenities and healthcare services, for devotees and tourists.

Chairing a meeting of the apex committee on pilgrim-age development, Fadnavis said the conservation and preservation of the State’s religious and historical sites was a priority for the Government and stressed the need for effective implementation of approved development plans. The committee approved development plans and funds worth ₹993.72 crore for six pilgrimage and heritage projects in the State. A sum of ₹172.22 crore was approved for the comprehensive and sustainable development of Bhimashankar Temple, one of the 12 Jyotirlinga shrines. The project includes a modern bus stand and parking facility, land acquisition, road widening from 2.7 metres to 7 metres, diversion roads, pedestrian pathways, covered corridors, flooring, an amphitheatre, a 257 KLD sewage treatment plant, a new police station and a rest house, an official release said. “Future proposals include a substation near Dimbhe Dam, a ropeway, development of

the Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation resort and tourism facilities at Rajapur. Fadnavis directed officials to complete the work by May 2027,” it added. The committee sanctioned ₹41.71 crore for conservation and development of the birthplace of Sant Tukaram Maharaj at Dehu, including the Vaikunthgaman temple and Bhandara Hill. The plan provides for road beautification, sanitation, drinking water, parking, accommodation for devotees, an information centre, tree plantation and environmental conservation, it added. A development plan of ₹134.80 crore was approved for preservation, conservation and beautification of Ajinkyatara Fort in Satara district. The project includes infrastructure development, viewing galleries, pedestrian pathways, landscaping, restoration of the Raj Sadar, conservation of bastions, tourist attractions, a suspension bridge and sanitation and rest facilities. “The State Government also approved ₹133 crore for the conservation of the memorial complex at Sangam Mahuli. The project covers restoration and landscape development of samadhis of Maharani Tarabai, Maharani Yesubai and Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj, conservation of the historic Sangameshwar temple and ghat, and construction of hanging bridge, viewing gallery and pathways,” the release said.

Indian Skimmer bird returns to Bihar sanctuary after 20 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Skimmer, an endangered riverine bird, has returned to the Vikramshila Dolphin Sanctuary in Bihar’s Bhagalpur after nearly 20 years, with the Jal Shakti Ministry calling the development proof of the improving ecological health of the Ganga river. The Indian Skimmer has long been considered an indicator species because of its dependence on healthy freshwater ecosystems and adequate fish availability. In a post on social media on Monday, Namami Gange - the official handle of the National Mission for Clean Ganga under the Ministry of Jal Shakti - said the Indian Skimmer survives only in river stretches where the water is clean. “This is no ordinary bird. It lives only where the water is



clean, the flow is right, and fish are plentiful. Where the river is sick, it does not linger,” the post said. Highlighting the significance of the sighting, it said, “Twenty years. Two decades. An entire generation.” It described the return of the bird to the dolphin reserve as “not just a signal but proof” that the water

quality is improving. “Biodiversity is coming back. The river’s ecosystem is heading toward balance again,” the post said, adding that the Ganga is a shared home for dolphins, fish, birds and millions of people living along its banks. “When the river heals, life returns on its own. This is just the beginning,” it added.

The Vikramshila Gangetic Dolphin Sanctuary in Bhagalpur, notified as a protected area, is an important habitat of the Gangetic river dolphin. In January, Jal Shakti Minister CR Paatil had inaugurated aquatic biodiversity conservation initiatives under the Namami Gange Mission, including the formal

launch of the Indian Skimmer Conservation Project by the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS). The initiative has given a structured and organised form to the ongoing efforts to conserve rare bird species along the riverine stretches of the Ganga. The project underlines that river conservation is not limited to water or aquatic species alone, but is steadily evolving towards balanced protection of the entire river ecosystem. “These species are not only indicators of river health, but are also symbols of the richness of our water resources,” Paatil had said. He also emphasised that by giving equal importance to uninterrupted flow, cleanliness and biodiversity conservation, the mission has adopted a multi-dimensional, scientific and integrated approach.

Kerala Govt unveils welfare schemes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The newly sworn-in UDF Government in Kerala on Monday announced a series of welfare measures, including free travel for women in KSRTC buses from June 15, enhanced honorarium for ASHA and Anganwadi workers, and the creation of a dedicated department for elderly people.

Announcing the decisions taken at the first Cabinet meeting, Chief Minister VD Satheesan said the Government had decided to implement two of the five guarantees made during the election.

It was Rahul Gandhi, while launching the election campaign in March this year, who announced five guarantees-free KSRTC bus travel for women, a monthly stipend of ₹1,000 for girl students in colleges, an increase in welfare pension to ₹3,000, health insurance coverage up to ₹25 lakh per household, and interest-free loans of up to ₹5 lakh for young entrepreneurs, which later became part of the poll manifesto.

He had also announced



Newly sworn-in Kerala CM VD Satheesan takes charge at the Secretariat in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday

the creation of a separate department for elderly people. Populist measures were announced after the UDF alleged that the State's finances were in dire straits.

In view of this, Satheesan said that a white paper would be issued detailing the State's financial condition and the Government exchequer.

"The first Cabinet meeting decided to implement two

Indira Guarantees offered by the UDF. First of all, free travel for women in KSRTC buses. It will be implemented from June 15 onwards. The details will be informed later," he said.

The Cabinet also decided to constitute a separate department for elderly persons, which the CM said could be the first of its kind in the country.

Satheesan said the way a

society treats elderly people determines whether it is truly civilised.

"We think the way a society respects old-age people is the measurement for checking whether that society is civilised or not. Our dream is that a day will come when Kerala can declare to the entire world that we are a civilised society and that we are looking after our old-age people decently,"

he said.

"Definitely, we have to protect each and every old-age person. We will not allow them to be alone. The Government is with them. Kerala is with them. That is the message," he said.

He said that, fulfilling a promise made during the prolonged agitation by ASHA workers in front of the Secretariat, the Cabinet approved an increase of ₹3,000 per month in their honorarium.

Referring to the agitation by ASHA workers, Satheesan said the UDF had honoured the assurance given to them during the protest.

"When the ASHA workers were on the streets in front of the Secretariat and had started a long-term agitation, I myself went there, and many UDF leaders also visited them. We had promised to take action to resolve their problems and that the first Cabinet would take a decision in your favour. So we kept our word," he said.

Satheesan said Anganwadi workers and helpers would receive an additional ₹1,000 per month.

DGHS issues advisory to protect citizens amid rising temperatures

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) under the Union Health Ministry, in coordination with the Ayush ministry, has issued an advisory suggesting cooling refreshments, breathing techniques and yoga practices to reduce heat stress amid rising temperatures.

In view of heatwave conditions prevailing in several parts of India, the AYUSH (Ayurveda, Yoga and naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, and homoeopathy) vertical under the DGHS, along with the Ministry of Ayush, has issued a comprehensive public health advisory for the summer season.

It provides a detailed guide for the general public, vulnerable groups, employers, workers and participants in mass gatherings and sports events to protect themselves from heat stress and related illnesses.

It emphasised adequate hydration, avoiding direct exposure to sunlight during afternoon hours, wearing light cotton clothing, and



A woman covers herself and a child on a hot summer day in Rishikesh, Uttar Pradesh on Monday

consuming seasonal fruits and electrolyte-rich fluids.

According to the advisory, infants, children, pregnant women, the elderly, outdoor workers, and people suffering from chronic illnesses such as heart disease and hypertension are particularly vulnerable during heatwave conditions and require special care and monitoring.

Special precautions have also been advised for workplaces, public gatherings and outdoor activities, including the provision of shaded rest areas, regular hydration breaks, acclimatisation measures for workers and awareness creation regarding symptoms of heat stress.

The advisory urged citizens to remain alert for symptoms of heat-related illnesses such as dizziness, headache, nausea, altered mental status, high body temperature, dehydration, seizures and loss of consciousness.

Heatstroke has been identified as a medical emergency requiring immediate medical attention, with the advisory recommending prompt use of emergency helplines 108 or 102 in severe cases. The advisory also incorporates traditional wellness and preventive measures from various AYUSH systems for combating heatwave conditions.

TN Government transfers over 10 IAS officers in reshuffle

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

In a major reshuffle, the Tamil Nadu Government on Monday transferred more than 10 IAS officers.

Gagandeep Singh Bedi has been posted as additional chief secretary, Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department, an official release said. P Amudha will take over as secretary, Cooperation, Food and Consumer Protection Department. Satyabrata Sahoo was transferred and posted as secretary in the Water Resources Department.



Shuchongnam Jatak Chiru was appointed as secretary, Public Works Department and Anil Meshram was posted as secretary, Energy Department. M Vallalar will be the Transport Department secretary, and KS Palanisamy as Revenue and Disaster Management Department secretary. Similarly, V Dakshinamoorthy was posted as secretary, Backward Classes, Most Backward Classes and Minorities Welfare Department.

Sajjansingh R Chavan was appointed as Youth Welfare and Sports Development Department secretary, and Prashant M Wadnere as Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department secretary.

GK Arun Sundar Thayalan will take over as Inspector General of Registration, and G Lakshmiopathy as Finance Department joint secretary.

CM Naidu directs officials to adhere to irrigation calendar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday directed officials to adhere to the irrigation calendar to ensure the timely completion of projects. Naidu had unveiled an irrigation calendar covering 25 irrigation projects during the recent collectors' conference.

"Follow the irrigation calendar for the timely completion of projects. Include 11 additional priority irrigation projects in the calendar apart from those already announced," Naidu said in a press release following a review meeting on irrigation projects.



Some of the projects and their timelines include the Cotton Barrage Gates foundation works (June 2026), Madduvalasa Phase-II (January 2027), the Polavaram Project (June 2027), Mulapalli Lift Scheme (December 2027), and the Upper Pennar Project (June 2028). Cautioning against negligence in imple-

menting the works, the CM also directed finance department officials to ensure adequate funding for land acquisition and civil works.

Officials informed the CM that 88 per cent of the civil works related to the Polavaram Project had been completed, along with 93 per cent of land acquisition and 45 per cent of rehabilitation and resettlement (R&R) work.

They also apprised him that the twin tunnels connecting the Polavaram right canal were 85 per cent complete, while work on the left canal approach channel, head regulator and irrigation tunnel was underway.



Presiding Officer of Judges Inquiry Committee Justice Aravind Kumar, Supreme Court of India along with Justice Chandrashekar, Chief Justice of the Bombay High Court; and BV Acharya, Senior Advocate, Karnataka High Court presenting the Report of Judges Inquiry Committee to Speaker, Lok Sabha in Parliament House

VHP hails mandatory Vande Mataram in West Bengal schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Monday hailed the West Bengal Government's decision to make the singing of 'Vande Mataram' mandatory in morning assemblies in State-run and aided schools, saying the move has "freed" the national song in its birthplace after decades.

VHP national spokesperson Vinod Bansal said the song, which played a role in India's freedom struggle, had remained "in bondage" in Bengal for the last 75 years.

"The 'Vande Mataram' that helped free the country from the chains of slavery has itself remained in bondage in its birthplace for the last 75 years. Due to pressure from a particular community, it could not attain freedom," Bansal said in a video statement.

He said it is the country's "good fortune" that a new Government has taken the step in Bengal, where the song was composed.

"In Bengal — the land where 'Vande Mataram' was composed — it has now been freed. Many congratulations and best wishes," he said.

Bansal said every student in Bengal will now necessarily begin the school day by singing 'Vande Mataram'.

"Every student in Bengal will neces-



sarily begin the day in school by singing 'Vande Mataram' and move forward in their academic journey. Congratulations and best wishes to the new chief minister of Bengal and to the entire country for this," he added.

Last week, the new BJP Government in West Bengal made the singing of 'Vande Mataram' mandatory in morning assemblies across all State-run and State-aided schools with immediate effect.

The directive, issued by the school education department, mandates that every student participate in singing the national song before the

commencement of classes, with school heads instructed to ensure strict implementation.

The order comes against the backdrop of an increasingly assertive emphasis on national symbols in public discourse and follows recent moves by the Centre to strengthen legal provisions concerning respect for the national emblem and song.

Announcing the decision, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had said, "From next Monday, 'Vande Mataram' will be introduced as the prayer song in all schools across the State. I will go to Nabanna today and inform them."

Telangana DGP reviews anti-Maoist operations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Telangana DGP CV Anand on Monday reviewed the Maoist situation in the State and assessed ongoing anti-extremist operations and intelligence measures undertaken by the SIB to address security concerns.

During his visit to the Special Intelligence Branch, the DGP appreciated the sustained efforts of its officers and staff in effectively countering Left-Wing Extremism and facilitating large-scale surrenders of underground CPI (Maoist) cadres, a press release said.

Between 2024 and 2026, a total of 820 Maoists, among them four Central Committee Members (CCMs) and 22 State Committee Members (SCMs), surrendered before the Telangana Police.

As part of these surrenders, CPI (Maoist) cadres also surrendered 334 firearms, including 58 AK-47 rifles, 48



INSAS rifles, 50 SLRs, six LMGs and other sophisticated weapons, it said.

The DGP commended the remarkable contribution of the SIB in effectively weakening the armed Maoist movement in Telangana through sustained intelligence-based operations, confidence-building measures and rehabilitation initiatives.

He particularly appreciated the proactive role played by the SIB in motivating underground Maoist cadres to shun violence and join the mainstream.

The DGP also reviewed the rehabilitation and reintegration measures being extended to surrendered Maoists.

Satheesan meets Archbishop to address Latin Catholic concerns



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Monday visited Archbishop Thomas J Netto amid reports that the Latin Catholic community was unhappy over the lack of representation in the Cabinet and concerns regarding the fisheries portfolio.

Satheesan is yet to announce who will be the fisheries minister. The CM reached the Bishop's House in the evening, where he was received by Netto.

He later held discussions with the Archbishop and other church leaders for around half an hour before leaving the venue.

Father Eugene H Pereira, Vicar General of the Archdiocese of Trivandrum, told reporters that the chief minister had assured them that the concerns regarding fisheries and coastal issues in the State would be addressed.

The Latin Catholic community is largely settled along the coastal belt, with a sizeable number engaged in fishing activities.

"Issues of the coastal belt are not given enough attention. There are several accidents during the rainy season. Following Cyclone Ockhi, a marine ambulance was built using donations received, but it was not used for rescue operations at sea for two months," Pereira said.

He alleged that such negligence had continued over the years.

Haryana Cabinet approves revised project cost of Gurugram Metro project

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

The Haryana Cabinet on Monday approved the revised cost for the Gurugram Metro project, supplementary reports related to integration with Rapid Metro and Gurugram Railway Station spur, and the proposal for funding of the soft loan portion of the project through the World Bank.

The decision marks a major step towards strengthening urban mobility infrastructure in Gurugram and accelerating implementation of the much-awaited metro connectivity project from Millennium City Centre to Cyber City, an official statement said after a meeting of the State cabinet.

The Cabinet met here under the chairmanship of

Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini. The detailed project report (DPR) for metro connectivity from Millennium City Centre to Cyber City, Gurugram covering a length of 28.50 km with 27 stations, was prepared by M/s RITES and approved by the Haryana Council of Ministers on August 13, 2020 and subsequently approved by the Government of India, it said.

The Cabinet has approved the revision of the total project cost from ₹5,452.72 crore to ₹10,266.54 crore.

The increase in cost is primarily attributed to price escalation between 2019 and 2023, revision in GST rates, standalone planning requirements for the Millennium City Centre-Cyber City corridor, requirement of a full-fledged depot and addition-

al rolling stock, modifications in the Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) alignment and provision of a metro spur to Gurugram Railway Station, the statement said.

The revised cost structure includes ₹7,098.70 crore towards revised project cost arising from escalation and GST changes, ₹947.06 crore for additional standalone corridor requirements, and ₹454.32 crore for construction of the metro spur from Sector-5 to Gurugram Railway Station.

The supplementary report relating to integration with Rapid Metro was also approved. The report outlines the cost implications of developing the Gurugram Metro as a standalone project after changes in the



integration scenario with Rapid Metro.

It includes provisions for development of a depot and associated facilities spread over 22.86 hectares of Government land in Sector-

33, Gurugram. Further, the Cabinet approved the supplementary report regarding the proposed metro spur from Sector-5 station to Gurugram Railway Station. The proposed spur, having a length

of approximately 1.80 kilometres, is aimed at improving multimodal connectivity and facilitating seamless travel integration between metro and railway services in Gurugram.

In another decision, the Cabinet approved the proposal for funding the entire soft loan component of the project through the World Bank.

The original sanctioned project cost of ₹5,452.72 crore included a soft loan component of ₹2,688.57 crore, out of which ₹1,075.428 crore was proposed from the World Bank and ₹1,613.14 crore from the European Investment Bank (EIB).

The Cabinet was informed by the officials that due to continued delay in receiving confirmation from EIB, the Board of Gurugram Metro Rail Limited, in its meeting held on October 13, 2025, decided that in case of further delay, the EIB-funded portion may also be financed by the World Bank in order to avoid

any adverse impact on project timelines.

The proposal subsequently received approval from the Chief Minister on December 12, 2025.

The Cabinet also approved the nomination of the Administrative Secretary, Town and Country Planning Department, Haryana, as the Nodal Officer for signing agreements and other related documents required for implementation of the project.

Further, the cabinet authorised Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini to approve any changes or modifications, if required, during consultations with the Government of India or for the removal of difficulties and bottlenecks arising during implementation of the project.

Editor's
TAKE

Prime Minister Modi's
five-nation outreach

Modi's trip signals that India's foreign policy is moving beyond traditional diplomacy to strengthen technology alliances and ensure supply-chain security

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is on a whirlwind tour of five nations. He is visiting the United Arab Emirates, the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy. These are difficult times for the world, as supply lines are disrupted and energy uncertainties are playing havoc with the planning of emerging economies. This is not just a regular seasonal disruption, but the cumulative effect of the world economy undergoing a seismic change.

Powerful nations such as the USA, China and Russia are busy establishing their respective hegemonies and working overtime to ensure that their national interests are best served. However, this has unleashed uncertainty, as no one knows for sure what comes next – Trump tariffs, the Ukraine war, or Chinese aggression in the South China Sea.

In this scenario, a country like ours has to chart its own course. Modi's international doctrine seems to stem from the erstwhile principles of non-alignment and neutrality, while staying out of power politics and, at the same time, connecting with countries that can not only provide what India needs but also offer markets for Indian goods and services. Prime Minister Modi has taken up the cudgels to spearhead the national campaign for self-sufficiency beyond borders. India is seeking investments, technology partnerships and greater strategic influence as it attempts to transform itself into a global manufacturing and innovation hub.

Modi's five-nation tour, is an exercise in diversifying imports and opening up to new avenues. The approach has found a ready partner in the Netherlands, where India and the Dutch government elevated bilateral ties to the level of a strategic partnership. The talks between Modi and Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten paved the way for cooperation and synergy on various issues. This move reflects the growing importance of the relationship beyond traditional trade. The partnership now extends into semiconductors, maritime security, renewable energy, artificial intelligence, defence cooperation and resilient supply chains. India's efforts to build a domestic semiconductor ecosystem cannot succeed without partnerships of this nature.

Modi's pitch to Dutch companies to "design, innovate and manufacture in India" aligns directly with New Delhi's broader ambition to reduce dependence on imports and integrate India into trusted global technology chains. The Scandinavian leg of the tour – particularly Sweden – was equally strategic.

Nordic countries are global leaders in green technologies, sustainable urban planning, innovation ecosystems and clean energy transitions. India's engagement with them is rooted in its need for advanced technological collaboration in areas such as hydrogen energy, climate resilience, smart manufacturing and digital governance. Sweden's strong innovation-driven economy and Norway's expertise in energy and maritime sectors make them natural partners for India's developmental priorities. As India expands economic relations with European nations, it is also subtly balancing geopolitical equations by building diversified partnerships across the continent, reducing its dependence on the US and China.

Satheesan's rise ends Congress rift in Kerala

After days of intense lobbying, internal rivalry and public pressure, the Congress finally chose VD Satheesan, exposing deep factional cracks within Kerala's leadership battle



KALYANI SHANKAR

The Congress party faced major challenges within its ranks while choosing Kerala's Chief Minister. The process lasted 11 days and proved crucial in resolving disagreements among various party factions, underscoring the importance of internal consensus in maintaining party unity.

VD was ultimately chosen despite stiff competition from KC Venugopal and Ramesh Chennithala. Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi reportedly took public sentiment into account while making their decision. Internal tensions surfaced throughout the selection process, but Venugopal eventually backed Satheesan's appointment in what was seen as a move in the larger interests of the party. The Congress high command itself appeared divided. Sonia Gandhi reportedly supported Chennithala, Rahul Gandhi favoured Venugopal, while Priyanka Gandhi backed Satheesan. These differing preferences revealed internal conflicts within the party leadership. At the same time, the Congress also faced pressure from its ally, the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), as well as from public opinion, both of which influenced the Gandhi family's political calculations.

Disagreements between Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi became visible through posters displayed outside Congress offices and Priyanka Gandhi's Wayanad office. One poster read: "Mr Rahul, KC may be your bag bearer, but the people of Kerala will never forgive you," reflecting grassroots opposition to Venugopal's possible elevation.

Rahul Gandhi played a key role in resolving the leadership deadlock by assessing public sentiment and coordinating discussions with Venugopal, Satheesan and Chennithala. He held extensive meetings in Delhi with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Sonia Gandhi to break the post-election stalemate within the United Democratic Front (UDF).

The IUML strongly backed Satheesan because of his secular credentials. Venugopal, after meeting Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi for more than two hours, expressed his support for Satheesan's appointment despite being a leading contender himself. He emphasised that the party's interests should take precedence over personal ambition.

A six-term MLA and the face of the UDF campaign, Satheesan had pledged to resign if the alliance failed to win at least 100 of Kerala's 140 Assembly seats. The UDF eventually secured 102 seats, with the Congress emerging as the single largest party, reinforcing confidence in



SATHEESAN NOW LEADS A LEGISLATIVE PARTY THAT STILL INCLUDES SEVERAL MEMBERS WHO DID NOT SUPPORT HIS ELEVATION. AT THE SAME TIME, HE RISKS ALIENATING SECTIONS OF HINDU VOTERS CONCERNED ABOUT THE PERCEIVED GROWING INFLUENCE OF MUSLIM ORGANISATIONS IN KERALA POLITICS

The author is a popular columnist

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 The Pioneer

Satheesan's leadership.

Rahul Gandhi's backing for Venugopal was complicated by the constitutional requirement that Venugopal resign from his MP post and contest an Assembly seat to become Chief Minister. Meanwhile, grassroots protests increasingly favoured Satheesan, who had emerged as a powerful opposition voice against the Pinarayi Vijayan-led government. He played a central role in bringing the UDF back to power after a decade in opposition.

The protests against the possible appointment of Venugopal highlighted the depth of internal divisions within the Congress. Satheesan himself acknowledged that these demonstrations shaped public opinion. The party now sees an opportunity to present itself as a strong national alternative to the BJP.

However, Satheesan's ability to reshape Kerala's political landscape will depend on several factors. While he enjoys broad public support, the Congress power structure and internal hierarchy remain significant considerations. During the 2021 Assembly elections, divisions between Christian and Muslim communities weakened the Congress and helped Pinarayi Vijayan secure a second consecutive term.

As Kerala's newly sworn-in Chief Minister, Satheesan faces immediate administrative and economic challenges, including a severe financial crisis, mounting debt and a widening revenue deficit. His ability to tackle these issues will define public confidence in his leadership.

His first major political test will be cabinet formation, which requires balancing competing Congress factions, satisfying alliance partners such as the IUML and preventing resentment within the party. He has already announced ten Congress ministers and later

inducted five IUML ministers.

Satheesan must also focus on economic revival, job creation and fiscal management while carefully navigating minority community politics. At the same time, he will have to counter BJP criticism regarding the Congress party's ties with the IUML and Jamaat-e-Islami, while maintaining internal unity and preventing sabotage from rival factions.

Emphasising inclusiveness, Satheesan stated that dissent is an essential part of democracy. "Those who dislike me, those who opposed me, and those who criticised me all have the right to express their views," he said.

Jamaat-e-Islami reportedly played a role in consolidating Muslim support for Satheesan. Maintaining his secular image while managing relationships with such allies will remain a delicate balancing act. He must also navigate the competing interests of Jamaat-e-Islami and Samastha, the influential Sunni organisation that quietly backed him.

Satheesan now leads a legislative party that still includes several members who did not support his elevation. At the same time, he risks alienating sections of Hindu voters concerned about the perceived growing influence of Muslim organisations in Kerala politics. This concern also extends to moderate and reformist Muslims uneasy about increasing communal polarisation.

Upon assuming office, Satheesan described the electoral mandate as a collective achievement. His success in building a cohesive administration and managing Kerala's political and financial challenges will determine whether his journey from Cantonment House to Cliff House becomes a defining chapter in his political career.



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Discipline: The foundation of a strong society



RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Discipline is essential for every living being, but for human beings, who are social by nature, it becomes even more important. Without discipline, society would descend into chaos, making peaceful coexistence impossible. Discipline is not something that can simply be learnt from books or imposed by others; it must become a natural part of daily life. From the moment a person wakes up until the time they go to sleep, discipline guides behaviour, thoughts and responsibilities.

The dictionary defines discipline as training oneself to act according to rules and maintaining a routine that develops skills and character. In reality, discipline acts as a control over emotions, actions and impulses. It helps individuals lead a balanced and organised life. Simple habits such as waking up on time, maintaining a healthy diet, exercising

regularly and managing time properly are all reflections of discipline. However, discipline is not limited to routines alone. It also involves inner control – the ability to manage anger, speech, desires and reactions. A disciplined person may not be flawless, but such a person is dependable, calm and trustworthy. These qualities earn respect and create stability in both personal and social life.

In today's world, indiscipline and the erosion of human values are becoming major concerns. Many social problems arise because people fail to exercise self-control and responsibility. No nation can progress without disciplined citizens. Lack of discipline often reflects frustration, dissatisfaction and a weakening of moral values. It leads to unrest, aggression and disrespect for social norms. What is often mistaken for freedom may actually be uncontrolled behaviour driven by the desire for attention and recognition. Such attitudes disturb peace within society and weaken the collective spirit of progress. The younger generation, in particular, requires proper guidance and constructive engagement. Youth possess immense energy, creativity and ambition, but without direction these qualities can turn into frustration and rebellion. Parents play a crucial role in shaping the character of their children. If they lead by example through honesty, sacrifice, understanding and integrity, children naturally learn to respect discipline. At the same time, children themselves must also take responsibility for their actions. Peer pressure and misguided

influences often encourage negative behaviour and indiscipline among youngsters. One of the biggest reasons behind growing indiscipline is the decline of moral and spiritual education in schools, colleges and homes. Modern education focuses heavily on academic success and career growth, but often neglects values such as patience, humility, tolerance and respect for elders. Spiritual and moral teachings help individuals develop self-control and emotional balance. They transform restless minds into responsible and compassionate personalities dedicated to society. Another concern is the blind imitation of foreign lifestyles and cultures at the cost of traditional values. Modernisation itself is not harmful, but abandoning one's cultural roots entirely creates confusion and weakens social identity. Indian culture has always emphasised respect, discipline, family values and harmony. These principles were carefully nurtured by previous generations, but many of them are gradually fading in today's fast-changing world.

Therefore, the need of the hour is to revive strong moral foundations and cultural values among the younger generation. Discipline must begin at home and continue through education and society. Only by combining modern progress with strong ethical values can India create responsible citizens and a peaceful society. Discipline is the foundation of growth, harmony and success.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

CAPTAGON SEIZURE RAISES SERIOUS SECURITY CONCERNS FOR INDIA

The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) deserves appreciation for busting an international drug racket and seizing nearly 200 kg of Captagon worth more than ₹182 crore. Captagon, widely abused in West Asia, is often referred to as the "Jihadi drug" because of its reported use by militant groups such as ISIS in conflict zones like Syria. This highly addictive synthetic stimulant increases energy, endurance and reduces fear, making it particularly dangerous. It is also commonly described as the "poor man's cocaine".

The seizure of Captagon in India is a matter of serious concern for law enforcement agencies because it indicates that India is being used as a transit corridor for shipments destined for Gulf countries.

Reports suggest that the consignment arrived from Syria through Indian seaports and was intended for re-export to Saudi Arabia.

Syria has emerged as one of the largest global hubs for the illegal production and distribution of Captagon, fuelling a multi-billion-dollar narcotics network across the Middle East.

India must therefore strengthen intelligence gathering, surveillance systems and international coordination to curb such trafficking networks. Strict monitoring of ports and cargo movement is essential to safeguard national security and fulfil the government's vision of a drug-free India.

RAMESH G JETHWANI | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Gujarat's roaring conservation success

Apropos "Gujarat leads global lion conservation: Yadav" (*The Pioneer*, March 15), the remarkable rise in the Asiatic lion population in Gujarat deserves appreciation. Globally, only around 20,000 lions remain in the wild, making India's conservation success highly significant. The lion population in and around Gir sanctuary has increased from 284 in 1991 to 523 in 2015 and now stands at 891, reflecting the effectiveness of sustained conservation measures.

The development of Barda Wildlife Sanctuary as a secondary lion habitat is a commendable step. Grassland rejuvenation, strengthening of the prey base and advanced wildlife tracking methods such as GPS, georeferencing and videography have contributed immensely to conservation efforts. The widely appreciated "direct sighting" method for lion counting has further improved monitoring accuracy. Preservation of wildlife corridors, regulation of sand mining and restricting train speeds have also strengthened lion protection initiatives.

India's International Big Cat Alliance and the ₹2,000-crore Project Lion indicate a strong commitment towards wildlife conservation. Such initiatives offer hope for the future of endangered species worldwide.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

India-Netherlands partnership grows

The recent decision by India and the Netherlands to strengthen defence and emerging technology cooperation through the signing of 17 agreements reflects the growing depth of bilateral relations. The move highlights a shared commitment to expanding collaboration in strategic sectors that are becoming increasingly significant in today's global landscape.

These agreements are expected to boost cooperation in areas such as artificial intelligence, cyber security, renewable energy, semiconductor technology and defence production. Such partnerships can support India's technological and industrial growth while creating opportunities for investment, innovation and the exchange of expertise. Stronger economic engagement between the two nations can also contribute to employment generation and sustainable development. The Netherlands and India can deepen ties in technology, clean energy, research and cultural exchange.

In an era marked by economic uncertainty and geopolitical challenges, stronger international partnerships are essential for stability and progress. The signing of these agreements is a positive step towards a deeper and more comprehensive India-Netherlands relationship.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

Vijay's historic political rise

The swearing-in of actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay as the new Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu marks a historic moment in Indian politics. Popularly known as "Thalapathy" among millions of Tamil film fans, Vijay has successfully transformed his cinematic popularity into a powerful political movement.

For decades, Vijay entertained audiences through Tamil cinema and emerged as one of South India's most influential actors. Many of his films carried social messages on education, corruption, poverty and youth empowerment, helping him build a strong connection with ordinary people, particularly the younger generation. In 2024, Vijay officially entered politics by launching his party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). Unlike several celebrities who remain symbolic figures in politics, Vijay actively campaigned across Tamil Nadu and projected himself as a leader focused on development, transparency and social justice. His simple speeches and direct public engagement earned him significant support.

The election results reflected public faith in Vijay's leadership. His journey from cinema star to Chief Minister is an inspiring example of democracy and public service.

JUBEL D'CRUZ | MUMBAI

From Anaimangalam to Leiden: Reclaiming a civilisation’s memory

A thousand-year-old Tamil inscription reveals advanced governance, global diplomacy, and a legacy now being reclaimed



ASHVATHAMAN ALLIMUTHU

The recent engagement between India and the Netherlands has once again drawn attention to one of the most remarkable historical records of Tamil civilisation, the celebrated Leiden Plates. Their renewed prominence reflects not only the depth of India’s civilisational past but also the growing efforts in recent years, under the leadership of Narendra Modi, to reclaim and reassert India’s cultural legacy on the global stage.

What appears at first glance to be a set of copper plates is, in reality, a deeply layered civilisational document. It is a record of diplomacy, governance, cultural exchange and administrative sophistication that places the Tamil people at the heart of an interconnected medieval world. In an age where history is often fragmented into regional narratives, the story of the Anaimangalam copper plates reminds us that Tamil civilisation was never isolated. It was outward-looking, confident and globally engaged.

The origins of these plates lie in a fascinating chapter of early transnational interaction between South India and Southeast Asia. Mara Vijayottunga Varman, the ruler of the Srivijaya Empire, who ruled Sumatra, present-day Indonesia, sought the support of the great Chola emperor Rajaraja Chola I to establish a Buddhist vihara in his empire.

This request itself is significant. It reflects the recognition of the Chola Empire not merely as a regional power, but as a civilisational force capable of extending patronage beyond its territorial boundaries. It also underscores the existence of deep maritime links between Tamilakam and Southeast Asia, facilitated by trade routes, cultural exchanges and shared religious networks.

Based on friendship, Rajaraja Chola provided land and support, enabling the construction of the Chudamani Vihara at Nagapattinam. This act was not simply a gesture of generosity. It was a carefully considered diplomatic and cultural investment, strengthening ties between two powerful regions of the ancient world.

Nagapattinam, during this period, functioned as a vibrant port city and a meeting point of civilisations. Merchants, monks, scholars and travellers moved through its shores, carrying with them ideas, goods and traditions. The establishment of the Chudamani Vihara there further elevated its status as a centre of spiritual and intellectual exchange.

To administer this vihara, the village of Anaimangalam was granted as a donation. This historically significant Chudamani Vihara, where Buddhist monks from Sri Lanka visited daily for worship, was later demolished on the orders of Governor Francis Napier, who accepted the request of French missionaries. The Napier Bridge in Coovum is named after him.

The grant of the village of Anaimangalam for the administration of the vihara was inscribed on copper plates by the son of Rajaraja Chola, the great emperor Rajendra Chola I. This act of inscription was not merely ceremonial. It was a formalisation of governance, a legal record that ensured continuity, accountability and clarity across generations.

These are the renowned Anaimangalam copper plates, the original name by which they were known, a unique historical identity of the Tamil people. Over time, due to colonial displacement and archival practices, they came to be widely referred to as the Leiden Plates. Yet, restoring their original identity is itself an act of reclaiming history.

These inscriptions, written in both Tamil and Sanskrit, vividly explain the artistic excellence, scientific knowledge and land measurement systems of the Tamils. One of the most remarkable aspects of these plates is the detailed recording of land survey methodologies. They reflect a structured and scientific approach to land administration, including precise demarcation, categorisation of land types, irrigation considerations, taxation frameworks and revenue assignments.

The sophistication of these systems is striking. Land was not merely distributed; it was measured, classified and documented with a precision that ensured



fairness and sustainability. Boundaries were clearly defined, responsibilities were assigned and revenue mechanisms were established in a transparent manner. Long before the emergence of modern cadastral systems, the Chola administration had already institutionalised a highly advanced and transparent model of governance rooted in measurement, accountability and documentation.

Beyond administration, the plates also illuminate the social and cultural fabric of the time. They record endowments, institutional management, rights of stakeholders and the integration of religion, economy and governance. They demonstrate how temples and viharas were not isolated religious spaces, but dynamic institutions that interacted with society at multiple levels.

The bilingual nature of the inscriptions demonstrates both regional rootedness and civilisational outreach, combining Tamil precision with Sanskrit formality. This dual-language approach ensured that the message was both locally grounded and widely intelligible across different cultural spheres of the time. During the period when the Dutch exercised control over parts of the region, these copper plates were taken away and later placed at Leiden University in the Netherlands, where they came to be widely known as the Leiden Plates. This movement of artefacts during colonial times was not uncommon, but it resulted in the displacement of historical memory from its native context.

For decades, such artefacts remained in foreign institutions, studied and preserved, yet physically distant from the people whose history they embodied. The question of their return was often entangled in legal complexities, diplomatic sensitivities and institutional inertia.

Today, these plates have been handed over to Narendra Modi ji during his visit to the Netherlands. This stands as a testament to his leadership and global stature. It is also a reflection of a changing global environment where nations are increasingly willing to acknowledge historical imbalances and take steps towards restitution.

Such a moment does not occur in isolation. Institutions and nations do not part with historically held artefacts easily. It requires a rare combination of diplomatic trust, moral legitimacy and sustained engagement at the highest level. In the present era, it is undeniable that Narendra Modi ji’s personality, his global credibility and his unwavering emphasis on civilisational pride have made such outcomes possible. His leadership has transformed cultural restitution from a passive demand into an active diplomatic achievement.

This transformation is visible across multiple instances. Artefacts that once seemed permanently lost to foreign collections are now being identified, negotiated for and returned. Each such return carries symbolic weight, reinforcing the idea that history is not static, and that rightful ownership and cultural memory matter. This is not an isolated instance. Across the world, several heritage artefacts connected to Indian civilisation, including those of Tamil origin, have begun to return or be acknowledged with renewed respect. These efforts signal a larger shift in how the world perceives India, not merely as a modern political entity, but as an ancient

and continuous civilisation reclaiming its voice.

Another significant moment that deserves attention is the Prime Minister’s address in the Ethiopian Parliament, where he drew a thoughtful comparison between the monolithic rock-hewn churches of Ethiopia and the ancient stone temples of Tamil Nadu. This observation carries deeper civilisational implications.

It opens up fresh perspectives on early architectural knowledge systems and interconnected human histories. The ability to carve entire structures out of single rock formations is a feat that demands an advanced understanding of geometry, engineering and material behaviour. By drawing parallels between Ethiopia and Tamil Nadu, the Prime Minister highlighted the possibility that ancient civilisations, though geographically distant, may have developed comparable technological and artistic capabilities.

Such comparisons challenge long-held academic assumptions and invite a re-examination of conventional theories, including simplistic interpretations of the Out of Africa narrative, by highlighting the possibility of parallel advancements and cultural exchanges across ancient civilisations.

When viewed together, these developments represent more than symbolic victories. They mark the re-emergence of a civilisational consciousness that had long been fragmented by colonial narratives and historical displacements.

They also raise an important question for contemporary India. Reclaiming artefacts is only the first step. The greater responsibility lies in studying them, preserving them and integrating them into public knowledge systems. Institutions, scholars and society at large must engage with these materials not as relics of the past, but as sources of insight for the present and future.

The Anaimangalam copper plates, in particular, offer valuable lessons in governance. At a time when land disputes, administrative inefficiencies and documentation challenges persist, these thousand-year-old records demonstrate the importance of clarity, precision and accountability. They remind us that good governance is not a modern invention, but a deeply rooted tradition in Indian civilisation.

They also reaffirm the global outlook of Tamil society. The interaction between the Chola Empire and the Srivijaya kingdom illustrates a model of engagement based on mutual respect, cultural exchange and shared growth. It is a model that remains relevant even today in an increasingly interconnected world. The Anaimangalam copper plates are not merely artefacts. They are evidence of a society that understood governance, measurement, diplomacy and cultural exchange at a level far ahead of its time. They represent a people who documented, administered and engaged with the world with clarity and confidence.

History was taken away, renamed and archived elsewhere. Today, it is being reclaimed, restored and rightfully remembered as our own.

The writer is a State Secretary of Tamil Nadu BJP and the founder of Project TamilAI and Science Saga

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The Pioneer

India’s crisis of imported gas and how to resolve it



DEEPAK GUPTA | DILIP KUMAR KHARE

In a world increasingly shaped by geopolitical instability, sanctions, conflicts and unpredictable leadership, energy dependence is no longer merely an economic concern; it directly affects national autonomy and strategic decision-making. As India charts its path towards a cleaner and more resilient energy future, national conversations are understandably dominated by solar and nuclear power. Yet, hidden in plain sight lies another transformative opportunity — one buried in our farms, landfills, cattle sheds, sewage systems and urban waste mountains. Biogas, and its upgraded form compressed biogas (CBG), offers India a rare solution that simultaneously addresses energy security, waste management, climate resilience, rural livelihoods, public health and fiscal prudence.

India today faces two parallel crises — waste and energy. Urban garbage dumps are turning into environmental disasters, rural waste remains underutilised and untreated sewage pollutes rivers and groundwater. At the same time, the country spends enormous sums importing LNG, LPG and fertilisers while subsidising their domestic consumption. Yet the raw material for reducing this dependence already exists in abundance. India generates over 700 million tonnes of agricultural residue annually, nearly 150 million tonnes of municipal solid waste, over a billion tonnes of cattle dung and massive volumes of sewage every day. This enormous waste stream can produce millions of tonnes of biogas while simultaneously cleaning cities, reducing methane emissions, improving farmer incomes, creating jobs and lowering import bills. The economic implications are staggering. A large-scale biogas revolution could potentially save India ₹30,000-40,000 crore annually in gas imports and fertiliser subsidies. It would support India’s broader developmental objectives, from Atmanirbhar Bharat and Viksit Bharat 2047 to the country’s net-zero commitments. The challenge is no longer technological feasibility. It is one of policy urgency, institutional coordination, financing models and implementation capacity.

Urban India represents perhaps the biggest untapped opportunity. Indian cities generate nearly 1.7 lakh tonnes of municipal waste every day, yet barely half is scientifically processed. If even half of the organic component of urban waste were processed through decentralised biogas plants, India could generate over 15 million tonnes of CBG annually. However, this requires systemic reform. Wet waste from vegetable markets, cattle yards and households should become feedstock for biogas plants, while recyclables and energy-recoverable materials should be separately processed. Crucially, cities need financially sustainable models that compensate waste collectors, aggregators and processors while integrating produced biogas into city gas distribution networks. Equally neglected is the massive biogas potential hidden in India’s sewage infrastructure. Hundreds of sewage treatment plants have been constructed under missions such as Namami Gange and AMRUT, yet most lack effective anaerobic digesters for gas recovery. Optimised sewage treatment systems could produce millions of tonnes of CBG while simultaneously recycling water at a time when Indian cities are approaching severe water stress. Every large sewage treatment plant should therefore be mandated to include anaerobic digestion and gas utilisation systems, supported by clear incentives and integration with urban gas grids. In rural India, the opportunities are even more transformative.

Millions of households possessing cattle can potentially shift from LPG dependence to household biogas systems. Earlier biogas programmes saw limited success due to weak maintenance structures and poor business models. However, innovative models are now emerging. In parts of Gujarat, private developers install and maintain household biogas units while collecting slurry to convert it into bio-fertiliser through cluster-based processing systems. The financial benefits are extraordinary. Under current LPG subsidy structures, the government bears a substantial subsidy burden annually for rural households. If millions of households transition to biogas, subsidy savings alone could run into over ₹1 lakh crore annually, apart from reducing imports. Rural families themselves would save thousands of rupees each year in cooking fuel expenses. Meanwhile, processed slurry can replace a significant portion of chemical fertilisers, reducing urea subsidies and improving soil health, water retention and long-term agricultural sustainability. Agricultural residue management represents another major frontier. India burns over 50 million tonnes of crop stubble annually, contributing heavily to air pollution and environmental degradation.

Yet this residue can generate substantial quantities of CBG. The SATAT initiative launched in 2018 aimed to establish thousands of CBG plants, but progress has remained disappointing due to pricing uncertainty, poor evacuation infrastructure and weak commercial viability. The lesson is clear: biogas cannot succeed without integrated policy support. Biogas also has a crucial role in India’s evolving renewable energy landscape. What India therefore requires is not another isolated scheme, but a unified National Biogas Mission. The next great energy revolution may not lie only in the sunlight above us. It lies equally in the waste beneath our feet, the sewage flowing through our drains and the agricultural residue currently going up in smoke. Every untreated litre of sewage, every burning field of stubble, every overflowing landfill and every unused cattle shed represents lost energy, lost wealth and lost opportunity. The clock is ticking. India cannot afford to waste its waste any longer.



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India is building its solar future, now it must plan for what comes after



POMPY KONWAR | PROMILA SHARMA MALIK

In Rajasthan’s Thar desert, where India began building solar farms at scale, many of the panels installed in the early 2010s are nearing the end of their 25-30-year lifespan. Across India’s 130 GW solar fleet, a clock is ticking quietly but rapidly. What happens when these panels reach the end of their life is a question India’s energy transition can no longer afford to ignore. India’s solar capacity has grown from roughly 4 GW of installed capacity in 2015 to over 130 GW today, with targets of 500 GW by 2030 and net-zero emissions by 2070. However, this clean energy transition also demands a credible strategy for managing solar waste.

The health risks of solar waste

A solar panel is far more complex than a sheet of glass mounted on a rooftop. Solar panels contain hazardous materials such as lead, cadmium, arsenic and hexavalent chromium

alongside valuable metals like silicon, silver, aluminium and copper. A standard crystalline silicon panel carries around 14 grams of lead in its soldering components alone. While these materials remain largely stable during normal panel operation, the risks emerge when panels are dismantled, broken, burned or processed improperly at the end of their life cycle.

Improper recycling or disposal can release toxic metal-containing particulates into soil, air and groundwater, leading to long-term health risks such as neurodevelopmental impairment in children, renal toxicity, reproductive disorders and elevated long-term cancer risks.

The coming solar waste surge

The scale of the challenge is no longer speculative. India’s Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (2021) projects solar PV waste to rise from around 34,600 tonnes by 2030 to nearly 1.8 million tonnes by 2050.

Embedded within this waste are both hazardous and economically valuable materials. These include toxic substances such as approximately 16 tonnes of cadmium and telluride, both capable of contaminating soil and water if panels are improperly discarded, and recoverable materials such as around 10 kilotonnes of silicon, 12 to 18 tonnes of silver, and substantial quantities of glass, aluminium and copper. Globally, solar panel waste is projected to reach 60 to 78 million tonnes by 2050, positioning India among the world’s major future contributors to solar waste generation.



Why recycling isn’t so simple

Recycling remains essential, but the economics behind it are challenging. India’s largest solar installations are located in remote, sun-rich regions far from recycling infrastructure, making collection and transport of end-of-life panels expensive. For many operators, these costs often outweigh the benefits of formal recycling. Without accessible and affordable systems, solar waste risks flowing into informal and unsafe recycling channels.

Beyond the economic viability of recycling, handling different solar panel components at the end of their life cycle poses a significant challenge. While materials such as aluminium are relatively easy to recycle and retain market value, nearly 75 per cent of a panel consists of low-value glass, silicon recovery requires costly processing, and valuable metals like silver and copper exist only in small quantities. Encapsulating materials such as ethylene vinyl acetate (EVA), which bind the panel layers together, are also difficult to separate. As a result, recycling costs often exceed the value recovered, making solar waste management both a technological and economic challenge.

What other countries are doing

Several countries have already begun developing policy responses to this emerging challenge. In 2023, South Korea introduced legislation requiring manufacturers to bear responsibility for the collection and recycling of end-of-life solar panels. The European Union incorporated solar panels under its Waste Electrical and Electronic Equipment (WEEE) Directive, creating mandatory recycling and recovery obligations for producers. Japan has similarly integrated recycling responsibilities into broader solar infrastructure management systems.

Despite differences in implementation, these approaches make manufacturers responsible for end-of-life disposal and material recovery. Evidence from multiple regions suggests that Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) frameworks can strengthen recycling systems when backed by enforceable regulations. Once producers become financially and operationally accountable for end-of-life management, they are more likely to invest in recycling infrastructure, improve material recovery and design panels that are easier to recycle.

What India needs next

India has begun moving cautiously in this direction. In June 2025, the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) issued draft guidelines prohibiting open dumping of solar waste and requiring disposal through authorised recyclers, formally recognising solar waste as a distinct waste stream. The question now is whether recycling infrastructure, logistics and enforcement can keep

pace with rising solar waste volumes. India’s solar transition will require stronger EPR implementation and expanded recycling infrastructure, particularly near remote solar parks where transport costs discourage formal recycling.

Public health must be integrated into solar waste management from the outset. Communities near recycling facilities should undergo routine monitoring for lead and cadmium, while public-private partnerships and academic institutions can support long-term surveillance systems. Continued research is essential to develop panels with higher recovery rates, longer panel lifespans and designs that are easier to disassemble and recycle.

Ultimately, the most effective waste-management strategy is to minimise hazardous waste generation at the design stage itself. India’s solar expansion is a major achievement, but its long-term sustainability will depend on how waste and health risks are managed. Recycling infrastructure, biomonitoring, worker protections and producer accountability must grow alongside power generation.

The panels being installed today will reach the end of their life within a generation, and how India manages them will shape the sustainability of its clean energy transition.

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Order Order

Delhi Police urges HC to cancel bail of rape accused

The city police on Monday urged the Delhi High Court to cancel the bail granted to a 57-year-old staff member accused of raping a three-year-old girl inside a private school in west Delhi's Janakpuri earlier this month. Justice Saurabh Banerjee issued notice to the accused, Lalit Kumar, on the police's plea challenging the trial court order which granted bail to him on May 7 in the case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. Terming it a "gross case", Additional Solicitor General (ASG) S V Raju said the accused faces a minimum punishment of 20 years imprisonment for the offence, but the trial court granted him relief within a few days of his arrest, despite the survivor identifying him as the perpetrator. "The 3-year old child has identified him.. Within seven days he was granted bail. This is gross case. This actually is a case of cancellation at the stage of notice," ASG Raju said.



SC grants bail to ex-IAS officer in DMF corruption case

The Supreme Court on Monday granted bail to retired Chhattisgarh-cadre IAS officer Anil Tuteja in connection with a corruption case involving alleged irregularities in the District Mineral Fund (DMF). A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi took note of the fact that the former bureaucrat was in jail since January 24, 2024 in various corruption cases. The CJI-led bench took note of the submissions of senior advocate Shueb Alam, appearing for Tuteja, that the former IAS officer was arrested in the DMF case on February 23, 2026. "The accused was arrested on 21 April 2024 and is in custody. The co-accused persons are already on bail. About 85 witnesses are sought to be examined against the petitioner. The conclusion of the trial is likely to take time," the bench said. "While it is true that the allegations against the petitioner are serious allegations, that will be a matter of trial. This matter is at the stage where the prosecution witnesses are to be examined. Taking into consideration the period spent in custody and the fact that the conclusion of trial is likely to take time, we deem it appropriate to grant bail to the petitioner," the court said.



SC STAYS COUNTING OF DELHI BAR COUNCIL POLLS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday stayed the counting of votes for the Bar Council of Delhi (BCD) elections following tampering allegations and asked the Delhi High Court to conduct day-to-day hearing on the pleas.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi passed the order while hearing a plea filed by Birender Sangwan and others.



The CJI transferred the matter to a division bench of the high court, urging the Chief Justice to constitute a special bench to hear the dispute on a day-to-day basis.

"Learned counsels for the parties have fairly agreed that since effective adjudication of controversy might require summoning of original records, such as ballot papers etc., it would be apt, if matter is entrusted to a division bench of the Delhi High Court. "Consequently, we transfer these petitions to the Delhi High Court with a request to the Chief Justice to list the same before a special bench within this week," the bench ordered.

The bench said till then the high court decides, "further counting of ballot papers shall be kept in abeyance. We have not expressed anything on the merits of the case. Parties at liberty to raise contentions before the High court."



AI should serve justice, not rule it: Justice Manmohan

AMIT KAUSHAL
■ New Delhi

While delivering former law Minister Dr HR Bhardwaj Memorial lecture on the topic "The emergence of AI and its implications for justice delivery and legal systems" on Sunday, Justice Manmohan underscored the Supreme Court's proactive measures, including the deployment of tools like SUVAS for vernacular translations and AI-based speech-to-text systems for transcribing oral arguments. He also highlighted "LegRAA," a generative AI tool currently in its pilot phase, trained on Indian case law. Furthermore, he noted the Chief Justice of India's recent unveiling of the "one case one data" initiative and the AI chatbot "Su Sahay".



Supreme Court Justice Manmohan delivering former Law Minister Dr HR Bhardwaj Memorial lecture on Sunday
PIONEER PHOTO

He reiterated the institution's core governing mantra: "Assistive, not determinative". Highlighting the rapidly evolving integration of Artificial Intelligence in the legal landscape, Justice Manmohan emphasised that technology must remain an assistive tool rather than a substitute for human judgment. Delivering a lecture on AI, he stated that

while technological advancements reshape justice administration, they demand a rigorous reckoning regarding fairness and reliability. Cautioning against blindly

copying global models, Justice Manmohan contrasted the efficiency of China's "Internet Courts" with their lack of human empathy. He also cited the American COMPAS tool as a cautionary tale of "black box" algorithms digitising systemic social biases. Turning to ethical hazards, he warned of "hallucinations", citing a New York case where a lawyer submitted completely fabricated, AI-generated precedents. This, alongside the Indian Supreme Court's recent observations in Usha Rani's case, shifts the traditional legal "Duty of Candour" towards a stringent "Duty of Verification".

The lecture further addressed data privacy and algorithmic biases. Justice Manmohan praised sectoral regulators like the RBI and SEBI for moving the needle from individual consent to institutional safety. He noted that the RBI's "Seven Sutras" mandate human-overrideable decisions to counteract hidden AI credit-scoring inferences, effectively re-humanising contracts. Advocating for open-source and transparent algorithms within the Indian judiciary, he warned against a digital divide that could create a two-tier justice system favouring the urban elite. Justice Manmohan concluded by calling for robust regulatory frameworks and university courses on AI ethics. Urging the legal fraternity to act as wise architects, he remarked, "Build the digital seatbelts before the accidents happen".

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SC grants bail to man accused of extortion

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday granted bail to an accused in a money-laundering case in which he allegedly posed as a close aide of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other Union ministers to extort money for getting people's work done. A bench of Justices MM Sundresh and N Kotiswar Singh set aside the Allahabad High Court order of February 5, refusing bail to Mohammad Kashif, who has been in custody for nearly three years. It granted bail to the



accused after he undertook not to use the names of high constitutional functionaries. The bench directed the

trial of the case, failing which the Enforcement Directorate (ED) will be at liberty to seek the cancellation of his bail.

The ED registered a case against him on April 19, 2023 based on a case of forgery and cheating lodged at Gautam Budh Nagar police station in Uttar Pradesh.

It was alleged the accused was involved in extortion of money from people for getting their work done from government departments by impersonating as a close associate of the prime minister and Union ministers. Inputs were generated from surveillance regarding national security, and suspicious activities were noticed with respect to Kashif for the last two years.

SC grants bail to narco-terror case accused

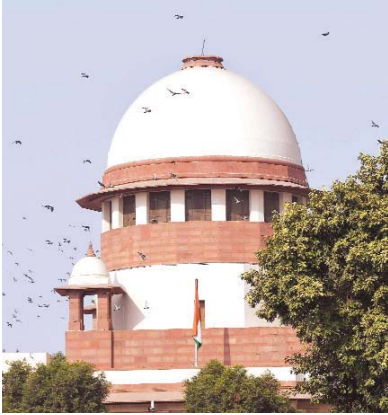
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Observing that bail is the rule and jail an exception even in UAPA cases, the Supreme Court on Monday granted bail to a man allegedly involved in drug trafficking and financing terror in Jammu and Kashmir.

A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan granted relief to Handwara resident Syed Itfikhara Andrabhi in a high-profile narco-terror case and directed him to surrender his passport and report to the local police station once in 15 days.

The NIA is investigating the case filed in 2020 under relevant sections of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act and the IPC.

The top court said Section 43D(5) of the UAPA cannot justify indefinite incarceration and must operate subject to Articles 21 and 22. The section outlines stringent bail restrictions.



Disapproving the judgment delivered by a two-judge bench in the Gulfisha Fatima case pertaining to Delhi riots, the apex court said it did not properly follow the judgment in KA Najeeb case which recognised long delay in

trial as a ground for bail in cases under the UAPA.

In the Delhi riots case, the top court had granted bail to several accused but activists Umar Khalid and Sharejeel Imam were denied the relief.

"Bail the rule and jail the exception is a constitutional principle flowing from article 21 and 22 and the presumption of innocence is the cornerstone of any civilised society governed by rule of law," the bench said.

"We have no manner of doubt in stating that even under the UAPA, bail is the rule and jail is the exception. Of course, in an appropriate case, bail can be denied having regard to the facts of that particular case," it added.

The apex court made it clear that its judgement in the KA Najeeb case is a binding law and cannot be diluted, circumvented or disregarded by trial courts, high courts or even by benches of a lower strength of this court.



HC grants interim bail to Engineer Rashid for father's funeral

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday granted interim bail till June 2 to Baramulla MP Sheikh Abdul Rashid alias Engineer Rashid, who is lodged in prison in a terror-funding case, following his father's demise.

A bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain said during the interim bail period, Rashid shall always be accompanied by at least two police officials in plainclothes, who shall remain with him from the beginning of the journey from Tihar Jail until his return from Srinagar.

He shall be permitted to visit the burial ground or any other place of worship, but shall not be permitted to move anywhere else from his residence in Srinagar and Langate, the bench ordered.

Rashid sought interim bail on the grounds that his father, who was undergoing treat-

ment at AIIMS, passed away on the intervening night of Sunday and Monday.

Rashid's counsel, advocate Vikhyat Oberoi, said interim bail was needed to conduct the burial, carry out the customary rites and perform various other ceremonies.

"Accordingly, due to the demise of the appellant's father, interim bail is granted to the appellant until 2nd June, 2026," the court ordered.

"Immediately, upon expiry of the bail period, the appellant shall surrender before the concerned Jail Superintendent and shall be brought back to Tihar Jail, Delhi," it added.

The court further ordered that any meeting between Rashid and persons other than his immediate family members shall take place only in the presence of the police officials and that he could use only one mobile number, which would be given to the investigating officer and kept "switched on" at all times.

SC orders two new election tribunals for bar council poll disputes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday ordered the setting up of two election tribunals headed by former apex court judges Justice Deepak Gupta and Justice Hima Kohli to adjudicate disputes arising out of state bar council elections.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi directed the Bar Council of India (BCI) to obtain formal consent of the two retired judges to lead the tribunals.

The order was passed to deal with a surge in litigation surrounding the conduct of bar polls across various states. "One election tribunal shall be headed by Justice Deepak Gupta and another



will be headed by Justice Hima Kohli," the bench said, adding, "Let the BCI obtain consent and let the two tribunals be constituted. All grievances (regarding the elections) are to be addressed to the tribunals formed".

The issue pertaining to 30 per cent representation for

women in state bar councils also came up for discussion during the hearing.

The bone of contention has been the "co-option" mechanism, which allows for up to 10 per cent seats to be filled by women if an insufficient number of them are elected through the standard process.

Robert Vadra withdraws plea against trial court summons in Haryana land deal case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Businessman Robert Vadra on Monday unconditionally withdrew in the Delhi High Court his petition challenging a trial court order that summoned him in a money laundering case linked to a land deal in Haryana's Shikohpur.

"Learned counsel for the petitioner, at the very outset, submits that as per his instructions, the petitioner is not interested in pursuing the present petition and they seek to withdraw the same unconditionally," Justice Manoj Jain recorded in the order.

The counsel for Vadra, the husband of Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, said he would make "appro-



priate submissions" before the trial court at an "appropriate stage".

All rights and contentions of the parties are kept open and the petition is disposed of, Justice Jain said.

Last week, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) had opposed the petition, contending that it was

based on a false legal submission.

The agency made the claim while countering the submission by Vadra's lawyer, senior Advocate Abhishek Singhvi, who argued that ED lacked the jurisdiction to probe the case as the offences filed against the petitioner under

the Indian Penal Code and the Prevention of Corruption Act were not "scheduled offences" under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act at the relevant time.

Singhvi argued that the land deal admittedly happened between 2008 and 2012, and the offences forming the basis of the ED case were only included in the schedule in 2013 and 2018. However, the ED's lawyer said the petitioner's contention was incorrect and was a "complete false statement on law".

On April 15, 2026, the trial court took cognisance of offences in the charge sheet filed by ED in July 2025 and asked Vadra and others to appear before it on May 16.

SC refuses to entertain PIL on wages of priests, temple staff

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to entertain a plea seeking to constitute a judicial commission or an expert committee to review the wages and other benefits given to priests, 'sevadars' and temple staff in state-controlled temples.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said that it cannot entertain the petition under Article 32 of the Constitution and those aggrieved can directly approach the court.

The top court asked petitioner advocate Ashwini

Upadhyay not to get into the affairs of priests as he may be unaware about the earnings of priests and 'sevadars' of temples.

Upadhyay said there are judgments of the Allahabad High Court and other high courts which call for reviewing the wages of priests of state-controlled temples to enable them to live a dignified life.

The bench refused to go into the petition and allowed Upadhyay to withdraw the petition with liberty to avail the remedy available under the law.

The plea, filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey,



sought directions to the Centre and states to constitute a judicial commission or an expert committee to review the remuneration and other benefits given to

priests and temple staff in state-controlled temples.

"Petitioner also seeks a declaration that priests and temple staff are employees under Section 2(k) of the

Code on Wages, 2019. Petitioner submits that once the State assumes the administrative, economic and financial control over temples, an employer-employee relationship arises and denial of dignified wages to priests and temple staff violates the right to livelihood guaranteed under Article 21," it said.

Upadhyay said the cause of action accrued on April 4, when he went to Varanasi to attend a public programme and after performing 'rudrabhishek' in the Kashi Vishwanath temple, which is controlled by the state, he came to know that even the

minimum wages to live with dignity are not given to the priests and temple staff.

"Recently, in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, priests and temple staff organised a large-scale protest demanding the minimum wages. Priests and temple staff are not getting even the minimum wage prescribed by the State for unskilled and semi-skilled workers. This is a systemic exploitation. The state is acting as a model employer through the endowments department, but violating the minimum wages Act and the directive principles of state policy (Article 43)," it said.

The plea further said the continued refusal to meet the minimum wages with the 2026 inflation-adjusted cost of living index had forced the petitioner to seek judicial intervention to prevent the further "marginalisation" of priests and temple staff.

Upadhyay further said the precarious nature of livelihood was starkly exposed on February 7, 2025, when a Tamil Nadu department issued a circular at the Dandayuthapani Swami Temple in Madurai, strictly prohibiting priests from accepting 'dakshina' in 'aarti' plates.

PIOTECH

Pope Leo XIV to launch pontiff’s AI encyclical on May 25



Pope Leo XIV and the co-founder of artificial intelligence company Anthropic will launch the pontiff’s first encyclical on May 25, a document on the care of human dignity in the era of AI, the Vatican said Monday. The presence of Anthropic’s Christopher Olah at the Vatican is significant, and suggests that the US pope’s position on AI will become a new flashpoint with the Trump administration.

In February, the Trump administration ordered all US agencies to stop using Anthropic’s artificial intelligence technology and imposed other major penalties for refusing to allow the US military unrestricted use of its AI technology. Anthropic is currently suing the administration, which it has accused of retaliating against it illegally because of its attempt to impose limits on how its AI technology can be deployed.

Leo, who has made AI a priority of his young pontificate, is greatly concerned about AI in warfare and has called for monitoring of how the technology is used.

The pope’s presence at the launch of the document, Magnificus Humanitas (Magnificent Humanity), is also significant, since such presentations are usually conducted in the Vatican press room with a few selected officials and invited guests who answer reporters’ questions about the document.

This time, the Vatican is bringing out an all-star cast for a formal launch in the main Vatican auditorium: Two of its top cardinals, doctrine chief Cardinal Victor Manuel Fernandez and development chief Cardinal Michael Czerny, will be the main presenters. Olah will be among the lay speakers, along with theologians Anna Rowlands and Leocadielushombo.

The Vatican secretary of state, Cardinal Pietro Parolin, will offer a conclusion, and Leo will make a speech and provide a final blessing, the Vatican said. Leo signed the document on May 15, 135 years to the day after his name sake, Pope Leo XIII, signed his most important encyclical, “Rerum Novarum” or Of New Things. That document addressed workers rights, the limits of capitalism, and the obligations that states and employers owed workers as the Industrial Revolution was underway.

It became the foundation of modern Catholic social thought, and the current pope has already cited it in relation to the AI revolution, which he believes poses the same existential questions that the Industrial Revolution posed over a century ago.

The new encyclical is expected to place the AI question in the context of the church’s social teaching, which also covers issues such as labour, justice and peace. Anthropic chief Dario Amodei had worked at OpenAI before he and a group quit to form Anthropic in 2021. They disagreed with OpenAI chief Sam Altman about AI safety.

Silicon Valley is spending \$700 billion on AI: Why is India trying to match the math?

History is a graveyard of state-funded tech projects eclipsed by commercial scale. We are walking straight into the same trap



NISHANT SAHDEV

In 1982, the global technology elite feared Japan’s “Fifth Generation” computer project. Armed with Tokyo’s billions, the state tried to build an AI supercomputer to break America’s computing monopoly. A decade later, the project closed — eclipsed not by a rival Government, but by the capitalised rise of the Silicon Valley personal computer.

Tech history is an unforgiving graveyard of state — funded vanity projects. Yet, walking through the corridors of power in New Delhi today, the exact same gears are grinding.

Consider the push for “AI Sovereignty” under the flagship ₹1 lakh crore Research Development Innovation (RDI) scheme to build a domestic deep-tech ecosystem. The narrative is alluring: India must build its own foundational artificial intelligence models, trained on local languages and free from Western ideological bias. It is a beautiful & patriotic vision. It is also an arithmetic impossibility.

Stripped of nationalistic marketing, a foundational rival to Silicon Valley is a dangerous mirage. By treating artificial intelligence as a matter of cultural pride rather than industrial scale, we risk misallocating public funds and missing the real technological disruption happening right under our noses.

The staggering cost of computing

To understand why India’s sovereign AI dream is imperfect, stop thinking of AI as software. Think of it as heavy manufacturing. Generative AI is the most expensive, resource — heavy infrastructure sprint in human history.

The four largest technology hyperscalers — Amazon, Microsoft, Alphabet, and Meta — spent a mind-boggling \$130 billion on capital expenditure in the first quarter of this year alone. For the full year, total Big Tech infrastructure spending is on track to cross \$700 billion. Alphabet alone recently raised its annual spending guidance to \$190

billion, gesturing it will spend whatever it takes to secure dominance.

This astronomical mountain of money is weaponised to buy high-end microchips, build hyper-scale data centers, and secure the staggering electricity needed to train next-gen models. A single frontier model requires tens of thousands of specialised chips working in perfect harmony. US tech companies are literally buying up nuclear power plants just to keep their AI clusters from crashing the public grid.

“Now, look at India’s playbook. The Government committed ₹10,372 crore (roughly \$1.25 billion) over five years to the IndiaAI Mission. Even with RDI scheme disbursements propping it up, the financial gap is comical.”

Silicon Valley is spending \$700 billion this year to dominate computing. India’s multi-year national fund to counter them amounts to pocket change. The entire annual allocation for our national mission wouldn’t cover the electricity or water — cooling costs of a top-tier OpenAI data center for a single month. You cannot fight a trillion-dollar computing monopoly with bureaucratic committees and modest innovation grants.

Physical and linguistic illusions

Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran flagged this truth in Economic Survey briefings, cautioning that India faces challenges as AI accelerates. He explicitly flagged the high resource consumption of data centers, gargantuan financial requirements for model development, and geopolitical constraints on hardware access, noting that public funding alone cannot bridge the gap.

Nageswaran is entirely right. Yet, domestic founders continue to claim that India can bypass this computing deficit by utilising our massive population.

This “data is the new oil” fallacy collapses under scrutiny. Raw, uncurated internet data is toxic sludge. To train a high-performing AI model, that data must be meticulously cleaned, labeled, and structured by human armies.

Furthermore, India’s linguistic diversity is a massive computational liability. Training an AI model



to be fluent in English is simple because the Western internet is filled with high-quality text. Training a model across twenty-two scheduled Indian languages, each with unique scripts and sparse digital footprints, requires exponentially more computing power and human moderation, not less.

When a domestic startup trains a model on vernacular Indian data, they operate under a severe tax. Silicon Valley giants already scrape Indian data, and they have the multi-billion-dollar infrastructure required to process it. Believing our data belongs to us simply because we generated it ignores the reality of who owns the refinery.

The fire in the IT backyard

By obsessing over the vanity project of building a “Desi ChatGPT,” Indian policymakers are looking at the sky while the ground beneath their feet erodes. They are ignoring the fire burning in our tech sector.

For three decades, India’s economic playbook was simple and successful: we educated millions of engineers, housed them in tech parks, and charged Western clients by the hour to write, test, and maintain software. This IT services sector became the ultimate social elevator for the Indian middle class.

But that model faces an existential crisis. Silicon Valley’s massive AI infrastructure investments are designed to automate the exact entry-level coding, testing, and back-office tasks that India currently exports. When global tech firms deploy advanced AI agents that can generate code in s



econds for pennies, the traditional Indian billable-hour model faces an eviction notice.

The warning signs are already here, with the Nifty IT index facing steep corrections and major players pulling back on bulk campus placements. If we waste resources trying to build copycat models three generations behind GPT or Llama, we fail to prepare our massive white-collar workforce for this shift. The challenge for India is not how to build AI, but ensuring millions of software professionals do not become obsolete overnight.

From builders to master deployers

Does this mean India should simply surrender and accept digital colonisation? Absolutely not. But it means we need to stop playing Silicon Valley’s game by Silicon Valley’s rules. We need to trade our expensive pride for ruthless pragmatism.

Instead of trying to build foundational models from scratch, India’s true leverage lies in becoming the world’s undisputed AI integration, auditing, and plumbing engine.

Silicon Valley wants the world to believe their software is a magical, plug-and-play miracle. It isn’t. It is incredibly messy, prone to hallucinations, and fragile when applied to legacy corporate workflows. Global

enterprises are discovering that you cannot just unleash an OpenAI or Google agent onto a banking system, an aviation network, or a healthcare infrastructure without an army of human babysitters keeping it from breaking things.

That is India’s real opening. Our technological future isn’t in competing with Nvidia chips; it’s in building the world’s most sophisticated workforce dedicated to duct-taping, auditing, customising, and fixing Silicon Valley’s half-baked software for global enterprises. India’s economic miracle didn’t happen because we invented the personal computer or the internet protocols; it happened because we became the world’s undisputed masters at deploying and scaling that technology to solve complex problems.

The exact same logic applies to the AI era. Let the American tech giants burn through three-quarters of a trillion dollars of their investors’ money trying to build the smartest machine on earth. Let them take the financial risks and suffer the astronomical depreciation costs of rapidly aging hardware. India’s job is to be the pragmatist who takes those foundational models, strips away the marketing fluff, and wires them safely into the real world.

We need to stop evaluating India’s technological progress by how many native LLMs we can announce at high-profile Delhi conferences. True technological power does not come from printing national flags on software architectures we cannot afford to maintain.

If we want to protect our economy and uplift our citizens, we must stop chasing the illusion of “Atmanirbhar AI” models. Our focus must shift entirely to becoming the world’s most sophisticated users and integrators of technology. We shouldn’t try to be the inventors of the engine; we should own the global monopoly on the mechanics who keep it running. Anything else is just an expensive exercise in national vanity — and in the fast-moving world of tech, vanity is a luxury India simply cannot afford.

The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems

AI rewiring India’s roads for a safer tomorrow

From real-time data to smarter enforcement, AI is reshaping how India prevents road accidents



RAJESH SETH

The National Road Safety Hackathon 2026, organised by the Indian Institute of Technology Madras, marks an important shift in India’s approach to one of its most pressing public safety challenges. Officially launched at the India AI Impact Summit 2026, the initiative positions road safety firmly within the country’s broader AI transformation agenda. Open to students, engineers, and technology enthusiasts, it reflects a growing recognition that innovative, technology-led solutions are essential to address India’s alarming road accident crisis. Yet, beyond such promising initiatives, a larger question persists: are we leveraging AI at scale to make our roads truly safer?

The scale of India’s road safety crisis

India records over 1.7 lakh road fatalities every year—more than 450 deaths daily. Behind each statistic lies a shattered family, a lost livelihood, and an irreversible social cost. Despite improvements in infrastructure and stricter laws, safer roads have not kept pace with faster roads. Recent incidents underscore a hard truth: human behaviour alone cannot be relied upon to ensure safety. This is where AI can become a game changer.

Implementing road safety programmes in India presents unique challenges. The country continues to grapple with a weak safety culture, low levels of formal training among commercial vehicle drivers, and an ageing vehicle fleet with poor maintenance. While traffic laws are stringent, enforcement remains inconsistent—allowing rash driving and unfit vehicles to persist on the roads.

Despite these constraints, India is witnessing the beginnings of a quiet transformation in road safety culture. With improving infrastructure and increasing use of technology, there is reason for cautious optimism that road crashes and fatalities can be reduced in the years ahead.

Paradigm shift from Reactive to Predictive Analytics

AI has the potential to fundamentally reshape road safety by shifting the paradigm from reactive response to proactive prevention. Through real-time data processing, predictive analytics, and pattern recognition, AI systems can monitor, detect, and even anticipate unsafe conditions before accidents occur.

In an interaction with this author, Dr Venkatesh Balasubramanian, Professor in the Engineering Design Department and Head of Centre of Excellence for Road Safety (CoERS) at IIT Madras, emphasised that “the application I am most optimistic about in the long run is predictive and prescriptive analytics—the ability to anticipate where crashes will occur, who is most at risk, and what intervention will prevent them, before a single life is lost.”

Power of data: ‘Battlefield actionable intelligence’

Launched in 2020, India’s iRAD (Integrated Road Accident Database) created a unified, real-time national database of road accidents. The eDAR (Electronic Detailed Accident Report) module, introduced by MoRTH in 2021 and scaled nationwide by 2022, extends this framework to enable end-to-end digital accident reporting and claims processing. With over two million crashes recorded, eDAR is generating AI-enabled insights for prevention and safer road design. Supporting this ecosystem is the Sanjaya platform, which ensures seamless data exchange across stakeholders, providing what Dr Venkatesh describes as “battlefield actionable intelligence to policymakers.” He adds that “we are now at the point where the AI layer can begin to deliver on its promise.” According to Dr Venkatesh, “computer vision and sensor-based AI are also showing significant promise in driver behaviour monitoring—detecting fatigue, distraction, and risk-prone driving patterns in real time.”

AI-powered traffic management systems can optimise signal timings, detect congestion build-ups, and dynamically reroute traffic. Smart



cameras, combined with AI, can identify violations such as red-light jumping, illegal turns, and non-compliance with helmet and seatbelt rules. For instance, AI-enabled traffic cameras are being deployed in Delhi NCR to detect violations like speeding, red-light jumping, and helmet non-compliance in real time, demonstrating how data-driven enforcement can improve compliance at scale.

The irreplaceable human factor

However, as Dr Rohit Baluja, President of the Institute of Road Traffic Education (IRTE), told this author, “the biggest mistake we make is believing that technology alone is the answer. AI and technology are enablers—they cannot replace human understanding, training, discipline, and scientific management.” He emphasises that road safety depends on a combination of safe roads, safe vehicles, trained drivers, effective enforcement, and responsible behaviour—areas where significant gaps remain.

Dr Venkatesh echoes this caution, noting that “India’s road safety challenge will not be solved by importing Western solutions wholesale. Our road envi-

ronment, traffic mix, urban morphology, and enforcement capacity are distinct. We need solutions designed for Indian conditions, tested on Indian data, and deployable within Indian constraints.”

Dr Baluja further argues that the more relevant question is: how can AI strengthen a scientific traffic management system? “Road safety,” he says, “is ultimately a product of such a system.” This distinction is critical. In India, the use of AI has largely been concentrated on enforcement. Yet, as he points out, “while challans have multiplied, fatalities have not reduced proportionately,” highlighting the limitations of a purely technology-first approach.

AI for pedestrian and two-wheeler riders’ safety

Interacting with this author, Dr Geetam Tiwari, Emeritus Professor at the Transportation Research and Injury Prevention (TRIP) Centre, IIT Delhi, points to AI’s potential in improving compliance, particularly among vulnerable road users. “Given the high risk to pedestrians and two-wheeler riders, AI can improve compliance — especially helmet usage and speed regulation

near schools — through automated ANPR (Automatic Number Plate Recognition) systems that generate penalties,” she notes. She also highlights AI’s role in proactive infrastructure management, where data can be used to identify “greyspots” and zones with repeated speed violations requiring engineering interventions.

Complementing these systems are the VAHAN and SARATHI databases, India’s unified digital registries for vehicles and driving licences, respectively. Together, they provide critical backbone data for enforcement, analytics, and road safety governance. As Dr Geetam notes, effective implementation will require overcoming challenges such as integrating these databases with AI-enabled



enforcement systems and strengthening existing enforcement mechanisms.

India is uniquely positioned to leverage AI for road safety, given its strong digital ecosystem, expanding startup base, and policy push under initiatives such as Digital India and Smart Cities. However, adoption remains fragmented and limited in scale. There is an urgent need to move from isolated deployments to a coordinated, mission-mode approach.

Data governance, policy architecture and innovation-to-deployment pipeline

Dr Venkatesh suggests that “Accelerating AI-driven road safety in India requires simultaneous action at three levels — data governance, policy architecture, and the innovation-to-deployment pipeline. We need a legislative mandate requiring stakeholders to contribute to and draw from a unified data ecosystem. MoRTH, NHAI, and state transport departments must embed AI-generated insights into planning and enforcement workflows. We also need an institutional architecture to connect ideas, technology, and

data.” Key areas for action include AI-enabled fleet safety, smart highways and expressways, urban traffic intelligence, data integration and analytics, and driver training and behavioural change. For AI to truly transform road safety, coordinated action is required across stakeholders — government agencies, urban planners, highway authorities, corporates, and technology providers.

Institutions such as highway authorities and city planning bodies must integrate safety as a core design principle, not an afterthought. AI deployment should be embedded into infrastructure projects from the outset. Public — private partnerships can play a crucial role in accelerating innovation and implementation.

Equally important is the need for robust regulatory frameworks and standards to ensure data privacy, system reliability, and interoperability.

As India builds faster roads and expands its transport networks, safety must keep pace with speed. AI offers an unprecedented opportunity to enable this shift — not incrementally, but transformationally. Road safety cannot remain a peripheral concern; it must become a national priority, backed by technology, policy, and collective will.

Collaboration as the force multiplier

Reflecting on the role of initiatives such as the hackathon, Dr Venkatesh observes that “A hackathon is an ecosystem event, not just a competition. It creates a rare space where academia, Government, and industry engage with the same problem and are compelled to think beyond their individual mandates.”

Ultimately, the success of such efforts depends on sustained collaboration. These stakeholders must remain aligned, committed, and driven by a shared belief that safer roads are not an aspirational ideal but an achievable reality. Safety is not a cost — it is an imperative. And above all, it is priceless.

The writer is Professor of Practice at IILM University, Gurugram, and has led large-scale logistics and road safety initiatives across India’s transport ecosystem

Nigeria, US forces kill 20 IS group militants

OPE ADETAYO ■ Lagos

The Nigerian military said Monday that a new operation with US forces has killed more than 20 Islamic State group militants in north-eastern Borno State.

The operation in Metele followed the weekend killing of Abu Bakr al-Mainuki, deputy leader of the group's local West African "province," marking a new development in the military cooperation. It was the first successful targeting of a senior militant leader by Nigeria's security forces after well over a decade of insurgency by armed groups, including Boko Haram.

The US military said no US or Nigerian forces were harmed in Sunday's strikes in the community near the borders with both Niger and Chad. Nigerian military spokesperson Samaila Uba said efforts "in close coordi-



nation" with the US military were ongoing to "disrupt terrorist networks, remove them from the battlefield

and deny the terrorists any safe haven within Nigeria."

The US and Nigeria entered a military cooper-

ation last year following a diplomatic row after US officials asserted that a "Christian genocide" was

occurring in the country that's largely divided between Christians in the south and Muslims in the north.

Nigeria's Government rejected the accusation, and analysts said it simplifies a complicated situation in which people are often targeted regardless of their faith.

In February, the US sent troops to Nigeria in what was deemed a mostly advisory and training role, but analysts say the weekend operation showed the cooperation has advanced to active US involvement.

Nigeria's military has long used airstrikes against militants in the escalating security crisis, sometimes hitting civilian populations with devastating consequences. Earlier this month, Amnesty International accused the military of killing 100 civilians at a market while targeting militants. The military (AP)

Pak forces kill 35 Balochistan-based terrorists, arrest three commanders

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Islamabad

Pakistani security forces have killed 35 members of Balochistan-based terrorist groups and arrested at least three senior commanders in intelligence-based operations in recent days, according to the provincial Government.

The security forces launched an operation on May 13 in the Mangla Zarghoon Gar area, a hilly area on the outskirts of the provincial Capital Quetta, which continued for four days, Balochistan Government spokesman Shahid Rind was quoted as saying by Dawn newspaper. "Security forces destroyed many camps and hideouts in the successful operation and arrested three commanders during the operation," Rind said, adding that 35 members of the terrorist groups were



killed in the operation.

The announcement came days after Quetta and other parts of the province were rocked by violence. Earlier this month, multiple

sites across the provincial capital came under rocket attacks, which were said to have been carried out from locations in the surrounding mountainous areas.

US anger over Imran's Russia visit led to his ouster as PM: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Washington/Islamabad

A leaked diplomatic cable suggests that the US' ire at then-Pakistan Prime Minister Imran Khan for his trip to Russia on February 24, 2022, the day of the attack on Ukraine, played a role in his removal from the office, according to an American media outlet.

The Drop Site News released a copy of the classified cable – called cypher – sent by Pakistan's envoy to the US Asad Majeed Khan to the Foreign Secretary in Islamabad, documenting his meeting with US Assistant Secretary of State for South



and Central Asia Donald Lu on March 7, 2022. According to the cable, the US official told the Pakistani envoy that Khan's visit to Russia had "created a

dent" in the bilateral relationship and suggested that "all will be forgiven" if the no-confidence motion against the Prime Minister succeeded.

"I would argue that it has already created a dent in the relationship from our perspective. Let us just wait for a few days to see whether the political situation changes, which would mean that we would not have a big disagreement about this issue, and the dent would go away very quickly," Lu told the Pakistani envoy during the meeting. According to the assessment of the Pakistani envoy, the US diplomat told him that if the no-confidence motion did not succeed, "it will be tough going ahead".

"I don't think how this will be seen by Europe, but I suspect their reaction would

be similar," Lu told the Pakistani envoy, according to the cable. The report suggests that the US was also upset with Khan for not allowing US forces to use Pakistani bases against Afghanistan. Khan was ousted on April 10, 2022, when a no-confidence motion against him was passed in Pakistan's National Assembly.

The Drop Site shared the alleged copy of the secret cypher on X. It was not clear if the shared cable was authentic, but it created debate on social media, with Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf party jumping in to use it for advantage.

"Now it has been proved that cypher was a reality. It is also true that it was stated in cypher that if no confidence movement against PTI and Imran Khan succeeds, then it will be in your (Pakistan) interest," Barrister Salman Akram Raja, said Secretary General, told a press conference in Islamabad.

The controversial cable first hit headlines when addressing a public rally in March 2022, Khan pulled out a paper from his pocket and waved it to the public, claiming that it was proof of the conspiracy against his government, which was facing a no-trust move.

23-year-old, youngest Indian-origin UK mayor elected

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

A 23-year-old politician representing a local council in eastern England has created history by becoming the youngest Indian-origin Mayor in the United Kingdom.

Tushar Kumar, a former student of Political Science from King's College London, took charge as the Mayor of Elstree and Borehamwood at a ceremony last week.

The Labour councillor

joined the Elstree and Borehamwood Town Council in 2023 and previously served in the role of Deputy Mayor. "An incredible honour to officially become the Mayor of Elstree and Borehamwood last night and, at 23 years old, the youngest ever Indian-origin Mayor in the history of the United Kingdom," said Kumar, in a statement following the ceremony.

"I am truly humbled by the trust placed in me and incred-



Tushar Kumar

ibly grateful for all the support, kindness and encouragement I have received throughout this

journey. Thank you to everyone who attended the Mayor Making Ceremony at Fairway Hall and to all those who have supported me over the years – from residents, community organisations and fellow councillors, to my family and friends who have always believed in me," he said.

He expressed gratitude to his predecessor, outgoing mayor Dan Ozarow, for his service and guidance during

his previous tenure as Deputy Mayor and welcomed Councillor Linda Smith as his new Deputy.

"I look forward to working closely together over the coming year serving our community. As Mayor, I want to focus on being present within the community, supporting local organisations and charities, and inspiring more young people to get involved in public service and commu-

nity life. It is the privilege of a lifetime to serve the town I love," he added. As one of the youngest councillors to be elected while still a student in London, Kumar believes that "real change starts at the community level".

"Elstree and Borehamwood Town Council gave me a platform to listen, represent and act – making a difference where it truly matters, close to home," he said. (PTI)

China responds positively to Trump's remarks on Taiwan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Beijing

China appears pleased with US President Donald Trump's softening stand on Taiwan's independence after his recent visit to Beijing.

After concluding his state visit to China, Trump on Friday struck an ambivalent



Guo Jiakun

note on the issue of Taiwan. He told Fox News that the US is not looking to have someone say "let's go independent because the United States is backing us".

The American leader also sounded uncertain about approving a \$11 billion weapons package for Taiwan. Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Guo

jiakun said on Monday that Beijing has taken note of President Trump's latest remarks on Taiwan.

"Taiwan is an inalienable part of China's territory; it has never been a country, and will never be one in the future," Guo said at a news briefing when asked to comment on Trump's remarks.

Congo opens 3 Ebola treatment centers to combat outbreak

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dakar

The Congolese health minister announced the opening of three treatment centres in the Ituri region in eastern Congo on Sunday evening as he visited the region amid the ongoing Ebola outbreak.

"We know that the hospitals are already under stress because of the patients," said Samuel Roger Kamba, the health minister, while visiting Bunia, the capital and largest city in Ituri. "But we are preparing to have treatment centres at all three sites in order to be able to expand our capabilities."

The World Health Organisation declared the Ebola disease outbreak a public health emergency of international concern on Sunday, after more than 300 suspected cases and 88 deaths in Congo and two in neighbouring Uganda.

Although the outbreak is centred in Ituri, cases have been reported in the capital, Kinshasa, and in Goma, the largest city in eastern Congo.

In a separate statement on X on Sunday, the WHO Regional Office for Africa



said that a team of 35 experts from the WHO and the Congolese Ministry of Health had arrived in Bunia, the capital of Ituri province, along with 7 tons of emergency medical supplies and equipment.

Ebola is highly contagious and can be contracted via bodily fluids such as vomit, blood, or semen. The disease

it causes is rare, but severe and often fatal. WHO's emergency declaration is meant to spur donor agencies and countries into action. By WHO's standards, it shows the event is serious, there is a risk of international spread and it requires a coordinated international response.

Jean Kaseya, Director-General of the Africa Centre

for Disease Control and Prevention, told Sky News on Sunday: "Currently I'm on panic mode because people are dying, I don't have medicines, I don't have vaccine to support countries. Yesterday I called for a meeting of all partners, we have some candidate vaccine, some candidate medicine, we are pursuing this route.

We hope that we can have something in the next coming weeks." Health authorities say the current outbreak, first confirmed on Friday, is caused by the Bundibugyo virus, a rare variant of the Ebola disease that has no approved therapeutics or vaccines.

Although more than 20 Ebola outbreaks have taken place in Congo and Uganda, this is only the third time that the Bundibugyo virus has been detected.

The Bundibugyo virus was first detected in Uganda's Bundibugyo district during a 2007-2008 outbreak that infected 149 people and killed 37. The second time was in 2012, in an outbreak in Isiro, Congo, where 57 cases and 29 deaths were reported.

संयुक्त बैंक

Indian Bank

ALHABAD

ALHABAD

Corporate Office: 254-260, Avvai Shanmugam Salai, Royapettah Chennai-600014

ANNEXURE VIII

(Sale notice format for Borrower/Guarantor/Mortgagor)

NOTICE OF SALE

Branch: Shantiniketan
Notice of sale under Rule 6(2) of The Security Interest (Enforcement Rules) 2002 under The Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002

M/s Surge Industries Partners: Mr. Deep Narayan Goyal & Mrs. Meena Goyal	Mr. Deep Narayan Goyal (Partner/ Mortgagor/Guarantor) S/o Madan Lal Goyal	Mrs. Meena Goyal (Partner/ Mortgagor/Guarantor) W/o Mr. Deep Narayan Goyal
a) Plot No.13 Phase-3, Barhi Industrial Estate Distt-Sonapat, Haryana-131101.	R/o B-27, Ground Floor, Village Bharola, Tagore Road, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033	R/o B-27, Ground Floor, Village Bharola, Tagore Road, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033
b) Village Ogthi, Tehsil Nahan, Kalamb, Distt. Sirmour, Himachal Pradesh-173930.		

Sub: Loan account – M/s Surge Industries
OCC A/c No. 7644038250, (TL - 7648060292, 7672506884, 7644269641, 7648067797, 7644264188, 7644017875, 7648062697 - these TL accounts are closed as on date) with Indian Bank, Shantiniketan Branch

M/s Surge Industries availed OCC & TL from Indian Bank, Shantiniketan Branch, the repayment of which is secured by Mortgage of schedule mentioned properties hereinafter referred to as "The Properties". M/s Surge Industries failed to pay the outstanding dues to the Bank. Therefore, a Demand Notice dated 08.07.2024, under Sec. 13 (2) of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 (for short called as "The Act"), was issued by the Authorized Officer calling upon Borrower(s) & Guarantor(s) liable to the Bank to pay the amount due to the tune of Rs.16,58,21,091/- (Rupees Sixteen Crores Fifty-Eight Lakhs Twenty-One Thousand & Ninety-One Only) as on 08.07.2024 with further interest, costs, other charges and expenses thereon. All failed to make payment despite Demand Notice dated 08.07.2024.

As M/s Surge Industries (Partners/Mortgagors/Guarantors) failed to make payment despite Demand Notice, the Authorized Officer took possession of the schedule mentioned properties under the Act on 18.09.2024 after complying with all legal formalities.

As per Sec.13 (4) of the Act, Secured Creditor is entitled to effect sale of the assets taken possession of and realize the proceeds towards outstanding balance. In accordance with the same, the undersigned / Authorized Officer intends selling the schedule mentioned securities in the following mode:

THE SALE PROPOSED TO BE HELD IS BY WAY OF PUBLIC TENDER /AUCTION ADOPTING THE e-AUCTION MODE.

*As per Rule 6 (2) of The Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 framed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002, 15 days' notice of intended sale is required to be given and hence we are issuing this notice.

The total amount due as on 30.04.2026 is Rs.93,13,741/- (Rupees Ninety Three Lakhs Thirteen Thousand Seven Hundred and Forty One Only) with further interest, costs, other charges and expenses thereon as are applicable.

Please take note that this is notice of 15 days and the schedule mentioned properties shall be sold under the Act by the undersigned/Authorized Officer any time after 15 days.

The date of sale is fixed as 05.06.2026 which would be by e-auction mode.

Inspection of the scheduled properties and related documents/up to date EC etc. by the intending purchasers/bidders may be done at their expense from 18.05.2026 to 04.06.2026 between 10.00 am to 4.00 pm.

The Reserve price and Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) for the sale of the secured assets is fixed as mentioned in the schedule.

The terms and conditions of e-auction is available in the website (<https://baanknet.com>). The intending Bidders/ Purchasers are requested to register with online portal (<https://baanknet.com>) (PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd.) using their mobile number and email id. Further, after completing their eKYC, the intending Bidders/ Purchasers have to transfer the EMD amount in their e-Wallet by 05.06.2026, 04.59 PM i.e before the e-Auction Date and time in the portal. The registration, eKYC and transfer of EMD in wallet must be completed well in advance, before auction.

Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) amount as mentioned above shall be paid online or after generation of Challan from the website (<https://baanknet.com>) (PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd.) for depositing in bidders EMD Wallet. NEFT transfer can be done from any Scheduled Commercial Bank. Payment of EMD by any other mode such as Cheques will not be accepted. Bidders, not depositing the required EMD online, will not be allowed to participate in the e-auction. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any interest. The Authorized Officer/Bank has the absolute right to accept or reject any bid or adjourn/postpone/cancel the sale without assigning any reason therefor.

The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% (twenty-five percent) of the bid amount, including EMD amount (10%) deposited, latest by the next working day and the remaining amount shall be paid within 15 days from the date of confirmation of sale in the form of Banker's Cheque/ Demand Draft /Account Transfer and/ or any other acceptable mode of money transfer. The Nodal Bank account no./ IFS Code etc. for online money transfer is as under.

Nodal Bank Account No. and A/c. Name	Branch name And IFS Code
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7162751804 INDIAN BANK ZONAL OFFICE AUTHORIZED OFFICER UNDS E-AUCTION INDIAN BANK, SOUTH EXTENSION BRANCH, NEW DELHI/IDIB000S032

In case of failure to deposit the amounts as above within the stipulated time, the amount deposited by successful bidder will be forfeited to the Bank and Authorized Officer shall have the liberty to conduct a fresh auction/ sale of the property & the defaulting bidder shall not have any claim over the forfeited amount and the property.

The sale is subject to confirmation by the Secured Creditor. The sale is made on "As is where is and as is what is" basis and no representations and warranties are given by the Bank relating to encumbrance, Statutory liabilities etc. If the e-auction fails owing to any technical snag etc., the same may be re-scheduled by issuing 7 days' prior notice.

This Notice is without prejudice to any other remedy available to the Secured Creditor and without prejudice to rights of the Secured Creditor to proceed with the proceedings presently pending before DRT/RO of DRT/ DRAT/ Court and proceed with the execution of order/deed obtained to be obtained.

SCHEDULE

The specific details of the assets which are intended to be brought to sale are enumerated hereunder:

Details/ Description of Mortgaged Assets	Hypothecation Of Mold For Plastic Part Of Remote Control-1 Set, Thermoplastic Plastic Injection Molding Machine Double Toggle Clamping System Including Accessories & Spare Parts-SM220EV2-4 Set, Mold For Plastic Part Of Remote Control-2 Set, YLSK 1020 Spring Machine-1 Set & Inventory/ Stocks situated at the premises of Plot No.13 Phase-3, Barhi Industrial Estate Distt-Sonapat, Haryana-131101
Reserve Price:	₹55.44 lakhs
EMD/Bid Incremental Amount	₹5.54 Lakhs/0.20 lakhs
Date, Time for e-auction And Property ID No.	05.06.2026, 10.A.M. TO 5 P.M., IDIB30604792156D
Prior Encumbrance	Not known to the Bank

Bidders are advised to visit the website (<https://baanknet.com>) of our e auction service provider PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. to participate in online bid. For Technical Assistance Please call PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. Helpdesk No. 8291220220, email ID: support.baanknet@psballiance.com and other help line numbers available in service providers help desk. For Registration status with PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd. and EMD status, please contact support.baanknet@psballiance.com.

For property details and photograph of the property and auction terms and conditions please visit: <https://baanknet.com> and for clarifications related to this portal, please contact Helpdesk No.8291220220

Bidders are advised to use Property ID Number mentioned above while searching for the property in the website with <https://baanknet.com>.

Place : Delhi | Date : 16.05.2026 Sd/- Authorised Officer

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Boost manufacturing to reduce imports: Goyal

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Monday asked the industry to identify goods that can be manufactured in India to help reduce import dependence of those products.

He also suggested increasing exports and buy goods manufactured in India, rather than importing them.

Addressing domestic traders, he said, “You should keep an eye on what goods are being imported, you will see opportunities in that too, what things can be manufactured in India.”

Goyal urged stakeholders to study import trends through the commerce ministry's trade portal and identify opportunities for domestic manufacturing and import substitution.

The minister said despite global economic uncertainties, triggered by Russia-Ukraine and West Asia crisis, India's exports rose about 5 per cent to USD 863.11 billion in 2025-26.

“This year's target is USD 1 trillion. This is a big target. We have to work together for this,” Goyal said, adding that the industry should focus on quality, improving competitiveness and enhancing scale of operations.

In the next five years, the government is looking at increasing the goods and services exports to USD 2 trillion. He added that the free trade agreements (FTAs) finalised by India will give preferential market access to Indian goods and help boost exports.

The FTA with Oman may be operationalised from June 1 this year.

Further, he asked to increase value addition in agri exports as it has crossed ₹5 lakh crore.

The minister launched a portal on Bhartiya Vyapar Mahotsav, which will be held from August 12 to 15 here at Bharat Mandapam. He asked the traders to showcase made in India goods only.

Goyal emphasised the need to promote domestic products and strengthen the spirit of Swadeshi, noting that even small preferences for foreign goods can weaken domestic industry.

He said India still depends heavily on foreign countries in sectors such as capital goods and called upon industrial clusters, including Rajkot, Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Batala, and Pune to increase domestic production instead of relying on imports.

Gold flat, silver moves up on import restrictions

Gold prices remained flat at ₹1.62 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Monday, while silver rates edged higher to ₹2.76 lakh per kilogram amid fresh restrictions on imports of the white metal and weakness in the rupee.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, the white metal appreciated by ₹1,000 to ₹2,76,000 per kg (inclusive of all taxes) from Friday's closing level of ₹2,75,000 per kg. Gold of 99.9 per cent purity was unchanged at ₹1,62,800 per 10 grams in the bullion market, according to the association.

Analysts said domestic bullion prices remained relatively resilient despite weakness in global markets.

Gold prices in the domestic market traded flat on Monday, following a sharp sell-off in the previous session, tracking weakness in the international bullion market, Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst — Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

However, losses in local prices remained limited as the Indian rupee weakened further to a record low of about 96.37 against the US dollar. The weaker rupee continued to cushion the decline in domestic gold prices, he added.

Market participants also reacted to the central government's decision to impose immediate restrictions on silver imports in nearly all forms, a move aimed at easing pressure on the rupee and curbing non-essential imports.

GOLD & SILVER

10g = ₹1,62,800*

₹1,66,000

₹1,62,800

₹1,62,800*

GOLD 10g

GOLD 10g

GOLD 10g

May 14

May 15

May 18

1kg = ₹2,76,000*

₹2,96,600

₹2,75,000

₹2,76,000*

SILVER 1kg

SILVER 1kg

SILVER 1kg

May 14

May 15

May 18

Spot gold prices for 24-carat in Delhi for per 10 grams

Source: All India Sarafa Association

Silver prices are in national capital for per kg

*Provisional

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | MAY 19, 2026

India to continue buying Russian oil, says official

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has been purchasing Russian oil irrespective of US sanctions waivers and will continue to do so based on commercial viability and energy security needs, a senior petroleum ministry official said on Monday.

“Regarding the American waiver on Russia, I would like to emphasise that we have been purchasing from Russia earlier... before waiver also, during waiver also, and now also,” Sujata Sharma, joint secretary in the petroleum ministry, told reporters at a media briefing.

Sharma said India's crude sourcing decisions were driven primarily by commercial considerations and adequate supply availability.

“It is basically the commercial sense which should be there for us to purchase,” she said, adding that there was no shortage of crude supplies

and enough volumes had been tied up through long-term arrangements.

A temporary US sanctions waiver allowing the sale and delivery of Russian seaborne crude expired on May 16, marking the second time Washington has allowed the relief measure

to lapse without clarity on an extension.

The general licence, first issued by the US Treasury Department in mid-March and extended in April, was meant to ease pressure in global energy markets after the US-Israeli war against Iran triggered the largest-

ever oil supply disruption.

“Whatever waiver or no waiver, it (availability) will not affect,” Sharma said.

Discounted Russian crude had risen to become the core of India's oil import basket since 2022, when Moscow's invasion of Ukraine triggered sweeping western sanctions

Stock markets end marginally higher

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended marginally higher on Monday after facing sharp losses in intraday trade, supported by value buying in IT and select blue-chip counters.

However, a weak rupee against the US dollar and rising global crude prices amid escalated tensions in West Asia capped the gains, traders said.

In an extremely volatile trade, the 30-share BSE Sensex increased by 77.05 points, or 0.10 per cent, to settle at 75,315.04. During the day, it tanked 1,134.78 points, or 1.50 per cent, to 74,180.26. A total of 3,034 stocks declined while 1,264 advanced and 194 remained unchanged on the BSE. The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 6.45 points, or 0.03 per cent, to end at 23,649.95.

“...market sentiment was nessed a mild recovery from intraday lows but remained largely weak due to a mix of global and domestic pressures. The rebound was primarily supported by value buying at lower levels along with selective strength in IT and pharma stocks, which helped the indices trim part of their losses.” However, the upside remained limited as

BSE SENSEX

MAY 18, 2026

PTI

CHANGE: +77.05 (+0.10%)

Previous Close

75,237.99

Today's Closing

75,315.04

TECH MAHINDRA

+4.38%

INFOSYS

+2.95%

SHARTE AIRTCL

+1.78%

BAJAJ FINSERV

+1.52%

SUN PHARMA

+1.34%

TOP GAINERS

↑

TATA STEEL

-3.21%

POWER GRID

-3.07%

SBIN

-2.38%

NTPC

-1.88%

TRENT

-1.88%

TOP LOSERS

↓

rising crude oil prices, continued weakness in the rupee near record lows, and sustained FII outflows continued to weigh on the market,” Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

From the Sensex firms, Tech Mahindra, Infosys, Bharti Airtel, Bajaj Finserv, Sun Pharma, HCL Tech, Bajaj Finance and Tata Consultancy Services were among the major winners. In contrast, Tata Steel, Power Grid, State Bank of India and NTPC were major laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.17 per cent, while the SmallCap Select index dropped 1.62 per cent. Among the sectoral indices, BSE Focused IT jumped 2.53 per cent, IT (1.95 per cent), Healthcare (0.22 per cent)

and Telecommunication (0.05 per cent). PSU Bank declined 1.81 per cent, Auto dropped 1.74 per cent, Consumer Discretionary (1.26 per cent), Metal (1.13 per cent), Consumer Durables (1.05 per cent) and Oil & Gas (1.01%).

“Markets witnessed a volatile session on Monday, with benchmark indices ending almost unchanged amid weak global cues and persistent macroeconomic concerns. The Nifty opened gap-down and remained under pressure during the first half of the session; however, a rebound in select heavyweight counters helped trim losses as the day progressed.

“The weakness was primarily driven by escalating geopolitical tensions in the Middle East after renewed

hostilities between the US and Iran intensified concerns over global energy supplies. Brent crude surged above the \$110 per barrel mark, fuelling fears over inflation, India's current account position, and margin pressure across crude-sensitive sectors,” Ajit Mishra SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 0.73 per cent higher at \$110.1 per barrel. “The Indian rupee extended its losing streak for the seventh straight session... driven by rising geopolitical tensions pushing crude oil prices higher. Additionally, a sharp uptick in both global and domestic bond yields signalled expectations of a prolonged high-interest-rate environment. Concerns over a widening trade deficit and declining forex reserves further added to the pressure on the currency,” Nandish Shah — Deputy Vice President, HDFC Securities, said.

The rupee weakened further and closed at a record low of 96.35 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday. In Asian markets, Japan's benchmark Nikkei, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng ended lower, while South Korea's benchmark Kospi settled in positive territory.

Rupee settles at record low against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Indian rupee weakened further and closed at a record low of 96.35 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, pressured by rising crude oil prices on the back of ongoing geopolitical tensions and a strong dollar.

Forex traders said the global market sentiments continue to dampen amid simmering tensions between the US and Iran.

Moreover, emerging market economies, including India, continue to feel the pressure of rising crude oil prices, as elevated rates increase the outflows of US dollars, along with the outflows already happening due to FPIs, traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.19, then fell further to 96.39 against the US dollar, registering a fall of 58 paise from its previous close.

At the end of Monday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 96.35 (provisional), down 54 paise from its previous close.

On Friday, the Indian rupee crashed below the 96/USD mark on Friday before closing at an all-time low of 95.81 against the US dollar.

cial, insurance, and trading channels.

This led to a brief moderation in purchases last year but the waivers led to Indian refiners stepping up purchases again. Russian oil imports into India are expected to average close to 1.9 million barrels per day in May, according to data from Kpler, near record levels. The figures include shipments covered under a temporary US sanctions waiver that has since expired over the weekend.

The continued flow of Russian crude comes even as Brent prices remain more than 50 per cent above pre-war levels, reinforcing India's push to secure cheaper supplies amid global market volatility.

Analysts said India is unlikely to move away from Russian crude in the near term. More documentation and tighter screening are expected rather than a structural shift in sourcing.

Rupee vs Dollar

₹ \$

₹ per US \$

95.28

-79p

95.66

+02p

95.81

-17p

95.68

-40p

95.64

+02p

96.35*

-54p

11

12

13

14

15

18

May 2026

(Inverted scale)

KBK Infographics

“We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias amid a strong dollar and rising US treasury yields. Ongoing geopolitical tensions and FII outflows may also pressure the rupee.

“However, any intervention by the RBI and certain restrictions on the import of gold and silver may support the rupee at lower levels. USDINR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 96 to 96.60,” Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Commodities Research, Mirae Asset Sharekhan, said.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.14, lower by 0.14 per cent due to simmering Iran tensions.

Indian markets capable of absorbing shocks: SEBI chief

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar

Volatility has shot up in the financial markets due to the ongoing West Asia conflict, but the Indian bourses have the capacity to “absorb different types of shocks”, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Monday.

When there is a crisis in one part of the world, it also impacts the rest of the globe, Pandey told reporters here on the sideline of the Regional Investors Seminar for Awareness.

“Due to the prevailing conflict in West Asia, the oil supply chain and its prices got affected in the rest of the world. All the economies have been affected by this and obviously, there are inflationary risks. Besides, spillover effect and second-order effect will also come in,” he said.

“However, the advantages of a resilient Indian market are that it is able to absorb different types of shocks, and when these end, the market again resumes its normal trajectory,” Pandey said.

He also admitted that there have been some foreign portfolio investment outflows since September 2024, but domestic investors have “retained their confidence”.

Current account deficit to widen to 2.3% of GDP in FY27: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India's current account deficit is set to widen to 2.3 per cent of GDP in FY27 from 0.9 per cent in FY26, a foreign brokerage said on Monday.

The balance of payments (BoP) deficit is estimated to widen to \$65 billion in the current fiscal from the last fiscal year's \$35 billion, it said. HSBC said it has assumed crude prices to average \$95 a barrel, and combined it with sensitivities in oil, gold, core goods, services trade and remittances to arrive at a current account deficit of 2.3 per cent of GDP in FY27 as against 0.9 per cent in FY26.

The BoP forecast has been made after growing through trends in portfolio inflows, FDI flows, and external commercial borrowing (ECBs), it said.

The report also looked at

forex reserves and opined that the nearly \$700 billion kitty seems sufficient from the traditional perspective, but suggested the need to look at it from a dynamic perspective, better for the current times of heightened risks amid recurring global shocks.

“Using a dynamic approach, we benchmark adequacy ratios against the lowest 10th percentile thresholds from India's own history to make sure minimum support levels are available,” it said.

While India is above all

the thresholds currently, it would fall below the 10th percentile threshold if the estimates on the BoP play out. Around \$30 billion of extra forex reserves via extra inflows or current account savings would keep all buffers above the 10 per cent threshold, it said.

“There is a two-fold challenge: lower the CAD and attract capital inflows that are sustainable,” it said, recommending policy actions including hiking pump prices for fuels.

“There is evidence from 2022 that adequate pump diesel and petrol price increases can take care of two-thirds of the extra funds needed,” it said.

Operationalising recently signed trade deals can raise India's growth prospects and bring back FDI flows, which have slowed, it said.

Report flags India's heightened susceptibility to cyberattacks, CBRN threats

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's geopolitical vulnerabilities, growing industrial sector, and rapid urbanisation have heightened its susceptibility to cyberattacks and Chemical, Biological, Radiological, and Nuclear (CBRN) threats, said a report released on Monday, emphasising the urgent need to strengthen its CBRN security strategy.

The CBRN defence and mitigation measures report was unveiled at a PHDCCI conference. “Strengthening the CBRN security strategy is increasingly urgent,

especially as regional tensions escalate,” the report suggests, stating that border conflicts and evolving security threats from neighbouring countries raise the risk of CBRN warfare and proxy attacks, underscoring the need for enhanced preparedness and response.

The report states that the CBRN threat landscape is not static — it is dynamic, adaptive, and increasingly technology-enabled.

For India, meeting this challenge requires a preparedness posture that matches the pace and complexity of evolving threats. This demands investment, coordina-

tion, innovation, and above all, a sustained commitment to collaboration across the full ecosystem of national security stakeholders, says the report.

“The Ukraine conflict demonstrates that chemical agents - including industrial chemicals not traditionally classified as “chemical warfare agents” — can be rapidly weaponised and deployed at scale in modern conflict. India's doctrine, detection systems, and protective equipment must account for this expanded threat spectrum, including drone-dispersed agents across wide frontages,” the report stated.

It pointed out that the Indian industry has demonstrated the capacity to develop world-class CBRN detection systems, protective equipment, robotics platforms, bio surveillance tools, and AI-based threat analytics.

“What is needed now is the structured engagement, clear procurement signals, regulatory clarity, and long-term partnership commitments that will unlock this capacity for national benefit. In the CBRN domain, the same industrial ecosystem that powers economic growth also underpins national security — making regulation, moni-

toring, and industry collaboration central to risk mitigation,” the report said.

Flagging the potential threat of cyber attacks targeting sensitive industrial systems and causing serious accidents, a senior official called for deepening collaboration between the Government and the industry, along with the integration of cyber resilience mechanisms with industrial security systems.

Roli Singh, Chairperson, National Authority Chemical Weapons Convention (NACWC), made the remarks while addressing the report launch event.

PROSPECT



NBCC (India) Limited signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with State Bank of India (SBI) on May 15, 2026, for extending a comprehensive Corporate Salary Package (CSP) to the employees of the company. The MoU was signed by Jyotsna Rani Moharana, DGM (SBI) and Sanjeev Kumar, CGM (HRM), NBCC in the presence of Anjeev Kumar Jain, Director (Finance), Ashwin P Kulkarni, DGM and senior officials from both organisations. The agreement further provides financial protection benefits including personal & accident insurance, permanent/temporary disability group term life insurance, health insurance, top-up facilities, rebate in loan facility etc.

Maruti starts production at 2nd Kharkhoda plant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd on Monday announced the start of commercial production at the second plant of its Kharkhoda manufacturing facility in Haryana.

The second plant has an annual production capacity of 2.5 lakh units, taking the total capacity at Kharkhoda to 5 lakh units, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) said in a statement.

With the new capacity coming in, the company's overall annual production capacity across its facilities in Gurugram, Manesar and Kharkhoda in Haryana, and Hansalpur in Gujarat stands



at 26.5 lakh units, it added. When fully operational, the Kharkhoda facility will be among parent Suzuki's largest four-wheeler manufacturing locations with capacity to produce 10 lakh vehicles per annum, the company said.

The country's largest car-maker had earlier indicated its plan to add 5 lakh units of capacity in FY 2026-27.

Assam Cricket Association hosts annual awards ceremony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam Cricket Association (ACA) successfully hosted its Annual Awards Ceremony at the auditorium of 91 Yards Club, ACA Stadium Complex, Guwahati, honouring players, teams, coaches, curators and support staff for their exceptional performances and invaluable contributions during the 2025-26 cricketing season.

In a grand gesture of appreciation for sporting excellence, Assam Cricket Association distributed cash rewards amounting to ₹12 lakh among 12 distinguished best performers who excelled across various categories during the BCCI Domestic Season 2025-2026. The semi-finalist Assam Under-16 Vijay Merchant Trophy Team was also hon-



oured with a cash reward of ₹12.5 lakh in recognition of its remarkable achievement and commendable performance at the national level during the 2025-26 season.

In the ACA Corporate Cricket Tournament, the champion team was felicitated with a Prize Money of ₹7 lakh, while the runner-up team received ₹3 lakh. Including individual awards worth ₹1.5 lakh, the tourna-

ment's total prize pool stood at ₹11.5 lakh.

The ceremony was graced by Honorary BCCI Secretary Devajit Saikia as the chief guest. Also present on the occasion were ACA President Taranga Gogoi, Vice President Romen Dutta, Secretary Sanatan Das, Joint Secretary Rajendra Singh, Treasurer Anupam Deka, and Apex Council Members Mukutananda Bhattacharjya

along with several dignitaries and members of the cricket fraternity.

Addressing the gathering, chief guest Devajit Saikia lauded the consistent efforts of the Assam Cricket Association in nurturing cricketing talent and strengthening the sporting ecosystem in the state. He praised the dedication and discipline displayed by the players and teams and acknowledged the invaluable contribution of coaches, curators and support staff in the growth of Assam cricket.

Congratulating all the award recipients, Taranga Gogoi reaffirmed the unwavering commitment of the Assam Cricket Association towards providing world-class infrastructure, quality exposure and greater opportunities for aspiring cricketers across the State.

RBI discontinues IFR requirement for banks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank on Monday discontinued the requirement for commercial banks to maintain Investment Fluctuation Reserve (IFR), an additional buffer to hedge against depreciation in the value of investments.

In view of the developments in the prudential frameworks governing market risk and investments for commercial banks, there is a need to amend the extant instructions, it said while issuing Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks - Classification, Valuation, and Operation of Investment Portfolio) Second Amendment Directions, 2026.

The requirement of IFR has been discontinued with effect from May 18, 2026, said a circular. The balance in the IFR as on May 17, 2026, shall be transferred 'below the line' to



Statutory Reserve, General Reserve, or Balance of Profit and Loss Account, it said.

For a foreign bank operating in India in branch mode, the balance in IFR shall be transferred directly to statutory reserves kept in Indian books or remittable surplus retained in Indian books which is not repatriable so long as the bank functions in India, RBI said.

The RBI has issued separate circulars on IFR for various bank categories, including cooperative banks, small finance banks (SFBs), and payments banks (PBs).

Surya Roshni shares rally on market buzz over possible business demerger

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shares of Surya Roshni Ltd have witnessed a sharp rally in recent trading sessions amid growing market speculation that the company may be considering a demerger of its business operations into separate entities.

According to sources familiar with the development, the proposed restructuring could involve separating the company's lighting

and consumer products business from its steel pipes and strips division. The move, if implemented, is expected to create two independently focused business entities, allowing each segment to pursue its own growth strategy and attract investors based on its individual performance potential.

Although the company has not issued any official statement or confirmation regarding the speculation, the possibility of a demerger has generated strong

interest among investors and market participants. Analysts believe that such restructuring exercises often help unlock shareholder value by enabling clearer business visibility, operational efficiency, and improved valuation for individual segments.

The market reaction has been swift and significant. Shares of Surya Roshni have surged from around ₹200 to nearly ₹253 within a short span, reflecting growing optimism surrounding the poten-



tial restructuring plan. Trading volumes in the stock have also witnessed a noticeable rise as investors closely track further developments.

Investors will now keep a close watch on any regulatory filing, board meeting outcome, or official clarification from the company regarding the reported proposal. Any confirmation of the restructuring plan could remain a key trigger for the stock in the near term.

NTPC group crosses 90 GW installed capacity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Reinforcing its key role in strengthening India's energy security and supporting the country's clean energy transition, NTPC Group has crossed 90 GW of installed power generation capacity. The milestone was achieved following the successful completion of trial operations of Unit 2 (800 MW) of Patratu Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Limited (PVUNL), a subsidiary project comprising 3x800 MW units.

This achievement marks another important step towards building a sustainable and energy-secure future for India.

Patratu Vidyut Utpadan



Nigam Limited was incorporated on October 15, 2015. It is a joint venture between a subsidiary of NTPC Limited, which holds a 74 per cent stake, and Jharkhand Bijli Vitran Nigam Limited, which holds the remaining 26 per cent stake.

PVUNL is committed to providing reliable and affordable power in an efficient and environmentally

friendly manner through the adoption of new technologies and optimal utilisation of resources.

With this addition, NTPC Group now operates more than 90 GW of installed capacity across the country. The company also has around 32 GW of capacity under construction. NTPC has set a target of achieving 149 GW total installed capacity by

2032, including 60 GW from renewable energy sources.

In its continuous efforts to boost renewable energy footprints, NTPC added 5,488 MW of renewable capacity in FY26 across solar, wind, and Pumped Storage Projects (PSP), accelerating its momentum on the journey of Viksit Bharat.

NTPC's diversified energy portfolio includes thermal, hydro, solar, and wind power projects, ensuring a reliable, affordable, and sustainable electricity supply across India.

In addition to power generation, NTPC has expanded into several new business areas, including e-mobility, battery storage, pumped hydro storage, waste-to-energy, nuclear power, and green hydrogen solutions.

Bajaj Auto Foundation invests ₹15 cr in advanced engineering skill centre at VIT

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vellore

Bajaj Auto Foundation, Pune, has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT) to establish the Bajaj Engineering Skills Training (BEST) Centre on the VIT campus. The centre will be set up with an investment of ₹15 crore and will offer state-of-the-art training in Electronics Manufacturing Systems (EMS) and E-Mobility. The initiative aims to bridge the growing skill gap between industry and academia by equipping engineering and diploma graduates.

Speaking at the signing ceremony, Sudhakar Gudipati, Vice President — CSR, Bajaj Auto Foundation, highlighted the rapid evolution of the manufacturing and automotive industries and



the resulting massive demand for a highly skilled workforce. He stated that Bajaj plans to establish more BEST centres across India to empower youth and address this gap.

G Viswanathan, Founder & Chancellor of VIT, expressed delight at the partnership and assured that the ₹15 crore investment would create an

immersive, cutting-edge training environment, giving VIT students a distinct competitive edge in the job market.

The centre will feature two cutting-edge verticals — E-Mobility and Electronics Manufacturing Systems (EMS). The E-Mobility vertical will provide hands-on training in EV Fundamentals & Architecture, Battery Technology & Pack Design, Battery Management Systems, and EV Charging Systems. The EMS vertical will offer comprehensive training in Electronic Design, PCB Design & Assembly, Surface Mount Technology, and Quality Inspection.

Ramesh V, Head — CSR, Bajaj Auto Foundation, outlined the initiative's vision and highlighted scholarship schemes for socio-economically disadvantaged students to ensure inclusive access to quality skill development.

DAILY SUDOKU

2			6			1		
1			8	9				
			7					
	6	3				1		4
9		8					2	4
						9	3	
	8		1		7			
				4	3			5
	2			8				9

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

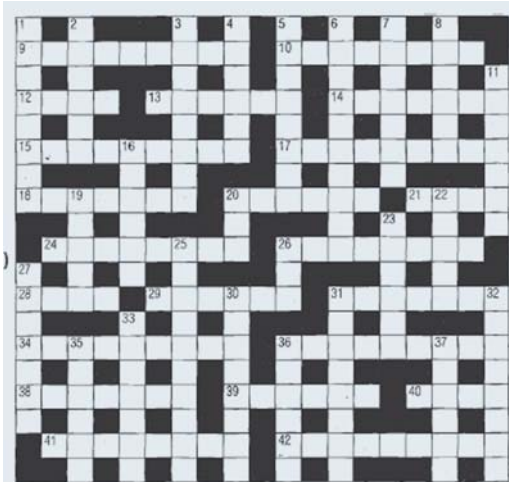
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (18.5.26)								
6	4	1	7	8	3	2	9	5
3	2	5	6	1	9	4	8	7
8	9	7	2	4	5	1	3	6
7	6	8	3	2	4	5	1	9
2	5	3	1	9	7	6	4	8
9	1	4	8	5	6	7	2	3
5	8	2	9	6	1	3	7	4
1	3	6	4	7	8	9	5	2
4	7	9	5	3	2	8	6	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | MAY 19, 2026



ACROSS

- Whatever happens and however fast you're travelling (2,3,4)
- Fancies capturing, in pictures (8)
- Winytry weather is healthy, you say (4)
- Spill the beans about a carousel (6)
- A quick way home, for the worker (7)
- Flower found in the jungle? (5,4)
- When I rang off, she had added the finishing touch to the dish (9)
- Shorten to the short "Are sick" (7)
- Names the various characters in (6)
- Undecided, to start with (4)
- Asked, pathetically, to be looked after (8)
- How the driller went on and on about

DOWN

- The way you refer to is "Backward and pitiable" (8)
- The salon called it back in (6)
- A friend back home got the data for the writer (8)
- Depend on me only (6)
- Double-talk? (8)
- Who whipped the cream? (3,7)
- Comfortable though not chic - and one didn't have to commute (5,2)
- Die in a shipwreck coming back again (6)
- Inclined to be, when looking after (7)
- If you think it out, it is justification for

his job? (8)

- With the hardwood, make a mess of (4)
- "Kicking up a dust", I gently interposed, "is silly" (6)
- Goes over one's adversities (7)
- Finds, too, in the records (9)
- Owning up, when giving notice to take a job on (9)
- That repartee of the woman's just makes one wilt (7)
- By ten, about, something cold to eat does seem tempting (6)
- The story is good - set in the City (4)
- Think it's about time to act as go-between (8)

- Winds up the entertainment at the Scottish festival? (5)
- Ready for collection (3)
- Unpleasant people you may tolerate only in small doses? (5)
- Pries up with metal objects (6)
- As it gains speed will, you understand, rock (7,3)
- The rotten fish is sent back (3)
- Follows, in the gloom (7)
- Tormented, looked for a way through it
- Twice invite a rebuke (4,4)
- Nice work if you can get it! (8)
- Go on a diet, out to look pretty when summer comes (7)

CARGO MATTERS
LAUNCHES ELECTRIC
BUS MANUFACTURING
IN KARNATAKA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Cargo Matters has announced the launch of its electric bus manufacturing operations in Karnataka with an investment of ₹318 crore, marking a significant expansion into India's rapidly growing clean commercial mobility sector.

According to a Press release, the move positions the company among a new wave of domestic manufacturers aiming to accelerate India's transition toward zero emission freight and passenger transportation. With operations across India, the United Kingdom, Bulgaria, and Australia, Cargo Matters said the Karnataka facility will focus initially on electric buses designed for inter-city transportation routes.

According to the company, the economics of electric mobility are becoming increasingly attractive for fleet operators. Cargo Matters estimates the operating cost of its electric buses at approximately ₹17 to ₹20 per kilometre, substantially lower than the nearly ₹50 per kilometre associated with comparable diesel powered buses from international manufacturers such as Volvo.

"The market needs this. When you benchmark against Volvo, the operational cost advantage is not marginal — it is transformational," a company spokesperson said.

The proposed vehicles are expected to feature battery packs exceeding 800 kWh, placing them in a performance category comparable to the Tesla Semi. The company said it intends to target major logistics operators, including firms such as Delhivery, while also integrating the trucks into its own freight operations.

The company stated that its integrated EV strategy — covering intercity buses, long haul electric trucks, and urban delivery vans — could be realised within the next five years, supported by advances in battery technology, favourable Government policies, and growing industry demand for cost effective low emission transport alternatives.

Jan Bhagidari Abhiyan launched to benefit tribal communities in Kamrup



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Jan Bhagidari Abhiyan, to be conducted from May 18 to May 25, was officially launched on Monday at the Conference Hall of the District Commissioner's office, Amingaon, Kamrup.

The launch programme was chaired by District Commissioner Deba Kumar Mishra in the presence of Boko-Chaygaon MLA Raju Mesh; CEO, Zilla Parishad, Siddharth Goswami; District Development Commissioner Susanta Kumar Dutta; ADCs Geetashri Lachit, Aditya Gogoi, Monika Buragohain; and other senior officials attended the programme.

The campaign aims to strengthen delivery of Government schemes and resolve grievances in tribal areas through awareness generation, entitlement drives, village immersion activities, health screening camps, and Jan Sunwai camps. Feedback from beneficiaries will also be collected to identify gaps in implementation and improve service delivery.

The DC informed that Adi Sewa Kendras will play an important role in facilitating outreach and coordination during the campaign. The programme will include entitlement drives, village immersion drives, Jan Sunwai sessions, documentation, and debriefing activities across the district.

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BRIEFLY

Scott Hastings, Scotland’s rugby great, dies at age 61



Scott Hastings, the Scotland rugby great who played alongside his older brother Gavin for the national team and the British and Irish Lions, has died. He was 61.

The Scottish Rugby Union announced his death on Sunday. In 2022, Hastings said he had been diagnosed with non-Hodgkin lymphoma and the SRU referenced a family statement that said he “deteriorated extremely quickly” due to complications with his treatment.

“He passed away peacefully and pain free,” the family statement read.

The most-capped center in the history of Scotland’s men’s team after making 65 appearances from 1986-97, Hastings was a member of the Grand Slam-winning team in the 1990 Five Nations and scored 10 tries for his country.

He and Gavin, who was three years his elder, made their first Scotland starts together in the 1986 Five Nations in a win against France. The teams shared that title.

(AP)

Dominant India U-18 men beat Australia 6-3 to level series



A clinical Indian U-18 men’s hockey team bounced back to register a commanding 6-3 victory over their Australian counterparts in the third match of the series at the Udhav Das Mehta (Bhai Ji) Central SAI Centre here on Monday.

With this win, the hosts have levelled the four-match series 1-1. India held the Aussies to a 2-2 draw in the series opener before losing the second match 1-3 on Sunday.

India took early control of the match with a blistering first-half performance.

Akash Deep (10th minute) opened the scoring in the first quarter, followed quickly by a strike from Shahrukh Ali (14th).

The hosts intensified the pressure in the second quarter, with Ketan Kushwaha (25th) and Romit Pal (26th) finding the back of the net in quick succession to give India a comfortable cushion.

Kushwaha (40th) continued his fine form to score his second of the match in the third quarter, before Ansh Bahutra (45th) capped off India’s scoring fest.

Australia attempted a fightback with goals from Owen Taylor (23rd), Oscar Freeman (29th) and Jack Weller (32nd), but the Indian defence stood firm in the final quarter to deny the visitors any further breakthrough and secure a comprehensive win.

(PTI)

Delhi HC denies Vinesh Phogat immediate relief for Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday refused to grant immediate relief to grappler Vinesh Phogat “without hearing the other side” after she sought a direction permitting her to compete in the selection trials on May 30-31 for this year’s Asian Games despite being declared “ineligible” by the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI).

The court, however, permitted her to give a “comprehensive reply” to WFI on the show cause notice issued to her over accusations of



indiscipline and anti-doping rule violations.

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav directed the WFI to take the show cause notice to “its logical conclusion” by July 6 and place its decision before it.

The judge issued notice to the WFI and the Centre on Phogat’s petition over her “ineligibility”, and said a balance must be maintained between the “competing interests” in this case.

The senior counsel representing Phogat argued that she should be permitted to participate in the

Asian Games trials scheduled for May 30-31.

He emphasised that while internationally, the ranking and status of female athletes on maternity leave are protected, the latest WFI policy excluded her.

“You have already been declared ineligible. How can we grant you that relief without hearing the other side... The (WFI) policy will have to be looked into. There are competing interests. Yes, we appreciate (that you were on a maternity break), but at the same time, national interest is there.

India seek redemption against French challenge at Malaysia Masters

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kuala Lumpur

A fresh India-versus-France battle awaits in the men’s singles competition and the Indian shuttlers will look to avenge their recent Thomas Cup semifinal defeat when the Malaysia Masters Super 500 tournament begins here on Tuesday.

India had won a bronze medal after suffering a 0-3 loss to France in the Thomas Cup semifinals in Horsens, Denmark earlier this month, losing all three singles matches. This week, three Indian singles players will once again face French opponents and will be eager to turn the tables.

While star Indian shuttler Lakshya Sen, who had missed the Thomas Cup tie due to an elbow injury, will open against Indonesia’s Moh Zaki Ubaidillah, Tharun Manneapalli will take on France’s Toma



Junior Popov, Kiran George will face seventh seed Alex Lanier, and HS Prannoy will meet Christo Popov.

S Sankar Muthusamy Subramanian will have to come through the qualifying rounds.

In men’s doubles, Hariharan Amsakarunan and MR Arjun, who did not get an opportunity in the Thomas Cup semifinal, will be keen to make a statement when they face the

seventh-seeded French pair of Christo Popov and Toma Junior Popov.

Among Indian women singles players, Tanvi Sharma will take on Thailand’s Pitchamon Opatniputh, sixth seed Unnati Hooda will face China’s Han Qian Xi, Malvika Bansod will clash with Germany’s Yvonne Li, and Anmol Kharb will meet eighth seed Denmark’s Line Hojmark Kjaersfeldt.

Praggnanandhaa held by Forest; Keymer surges ahead



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bucharest (Romania)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa played out a draw with Dutchman Jorden Van Forest even as Germany’s Vincent Keymer surged ahead following a facile victory in the fourth round of Super Chess Classic here.

With a sole win over Alireza Firouzja of France and three draws, Praggnanandhaa inched to 2.5 points out of a possible four while Vincent moved to sole lead on three points after beating French Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France.

On a day when Anish Giri also got an easy draw against World Championships challenger Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, Wesley So was also held to a draw by Deac Bogdan-Daniel of Romania.

Firouzja abstained from playing the fourth round citing health issues.

Very hard to say who will win the World Championship titles: Anna Muzychuk

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Former world blitz and rapid champion Anna Muzychuk has declined to pick favourites for this year’s men’s and women’s world championship titles with Indian players D Gukesh and R Vaishali set to face tough rivals later this year, saying psychological momentum and handling pressure could prove decisive in the summit clash.

Muzychuk, one of Ukraine’s finest chess players who will begin her Norway Chess title defence in a few days in Oslo, said the World Championship clashes featuring defending champion Gukesh against challenger Javokhir Sindarov in the ‘Open’ section and Vaishali against five-time world champion Ju Wenjun in the women’s event promise high drama and excitement regardless of who emerges victorious.



“It will be very interesting clash. I’m looking forward to watching both of them (Open and Women’s title show-downs) because the World Championship matches always stand out,” said the 36-year-old Grandmaster, whose best in the classical World Championship format has been a runner-up finish in 2017.

Having experienced the highs and lows, and pressures

of elite chess first hand, the former world No. 2 said a lot can change before the title showdowns, as momentum and fortunes can swing dramatically over time.

They (world championships) are always special and they bring a lot of excitement, especially for the spectators. It’s very hard to say who will win or who is the favourite because there is still a lot of time.

Barcelona win in Lewandowski farewell

TALES AZZONI ■ Madrid

Spanish champion Barcelona capped a perfect season at home — 19 wins in 19 La Liga matches — with a 3-1 victory over Real Betis on Sunday as Robert Lewandowski bid an emotional farewell to Camp Nou. Barcelona announced Saturday that the 37-year-old Lewandowski was leaving after four seasons.

Antoine Griezmann also said goodbye to Atletico Madrid’s fans at the Metropolitano stadium before he moves to the United States to play in Major League Soccer. Atletico beat Girona 1-0.

Two goals by Raphinha and one by Joao Cancelo kept Barcelona perfect at home in the Spanish league. The Catalan club had already clinched its second straight league title two rounds ago.

There is one round of matches left. Lewandowski helped Barcelona win three Spanish league titles in four seasons, including this campaign, and one Copa del Rey, while scoring an impressive 119 goals in 192 appearances.

It was an emotional farewell for the Poland striker, who, after the match, was thrown into the air by



his teammates. They also lined up and applauded Lewandowski as he went toward the locker room.

“It has been an honour to play for this club,” Lewandowski said. “We’ve enjoyed some great moments in these four years. I am very proud of everything we have achieved together. Today I say goodbye, but I will always carry Barcelona in my heart. Thank you so much, fans. Once a Barca fan, always a Barca fan.”

Griezmann’s goodbye: Griezmann

is Atletico’s all-time leading scorer. The French forward apologised again to fans on Sunday for having left Atletico to play for rival Barcelona.

“I didn’t realise how much I loved you here. I was very young. I made a mistake, I reconsidered, and we did everything we could to come back and enjoy it again,” he said. Atletico coach Diego Simeone praised the 35-year-old Griezmann.

“Griezmann is possibly the best one to have ever played here,”

Simeone said. “He’s an extraordinary guy, a genius. He’s the most game-changing player that we’ve coached here.”

Mbappe starts, Sevilla loses but survives: Sevilla avoided relegation despite a 1-0 loss to Real Madrid at home.

Vinicius Junior scored for Madrid, which had

already sealed second place. Kylian Mbappe started for Madrid three days after saying coach Alvaro Arbeloa had made him the team’s fourth-choice striker. He came off the bench in the win at Oviedo on Thursday in what was his return from an injury layoff.

It was a tight relegation fight coming into Sunday’s matches, and Sevilla secured its salvation thanks to other results. Alaves also guaranteed more top-tier soccer next season with a 1-0 win at already relegated Oviedo.

Five teams will enter next weekend’s final round looking to avoid the drop: Levante, Osasuna, Elche, Girona and Mallorca. Levante moved closer to safety with a 2-0 win over Mallorca and is 15th with 42 points, the same number of points as 16th-place Osasuna and 17th-place Elche.

(AP)



Lille finishes third in Ligue 1 to secure Champions League berth despite losing to Auxerre



SAMUEL PETREQUIN ■ Paris

Lille finished the Ligue 1 season in third place to secure a berth in next season’s Champions League despite losing 2-0 at home to Auxerre on the final day, and already crowned French champion Paris Saint-Germain concluded its domestic campaign on a poor note.

Three clubs — Lille, Lyon and Rennes — could have still finished third before Sunday’s final round of matches and join champion PSG and runner-up Lens in Europe’s top club competition. But none of the trio managed to win, and Lille secured the coveted spot, one point above Lyon, which will go into Champions League qualifying.

Mali forward Lassine Sinayoko scored a brace for Auxerre, making sure his team would remain in the top flight and avoid the relegation playoff.

“This is not the match we wanted to play, but the main thing is that we finish third, it’s the reward for a whole season, we should not focus on this final match,” Lille captain Benjamin Andre said.

“This is very important for the club. Everybody wants to play in the Champions League.”

Lyon’s hopes of finishing third quickly faded as coach Paulo Fonseca’s players trailed by three goals before halftime at home against Lens. Florian Thauvin added another goal in the second half to seal the visitors’ 4-0 win.

Meanwhile, Marseille beat Rennes 3-1 with goals from Pierre-Emile Hojbjerg, Amine Gouiri and Pierre-Emerick Aubameyang. Esteban Lepaul, the league’s top scorer, reduced the deficit with his 21st goal this season.

The win lifted Marseille to fifth place — level on points with Rennes but with a better goal difference — and into the Europa League.

In Paris, PSG, which sealed its 14th league title on Wednesday, made a short trip to its neighbour Paris FC and concluded its domestic season with a 2-1 loss.

Bradley Barcola put PSG in front only for Alimami Gory to level in the 76th and complete his brace in added time. PSG had been knocked out of the French Cup by Paris FC in January.

(AP)

SRH beat CSK by five wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Ishan Kishan struck a fluent 70 after Pat Cummins displayed his mastery over length and pace with a three-wicket burst as Sunrisers Hyderabad ensured an IPL 2026 playoff berth with a smooth five-wicket victory over Chennai Super Kings here on Monday.

Chasing 181 was never going to be easy on a slowish Chepauk track. But Kishan, who hammered seven fours and three sixes in his 47-ball knock, and an equally enterprising Heinrich Klaasen (47 off 26 balls) added 75 runs for the third wicket, powering Hyderabad to 181 for five in 19 overs.

SRH now have 16 points with a game in hand – good enough to carry them to the playoffs and the night's result meant that Gujarat Titans (16 points) also marched into the knockouts.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (18 points) have already sealed their place in the playoffs, leaving other contenders to fight it out for the lone remaining place.

The Super Kings, who have 12 points from 13 matches, also are not yet completely out of the race to the knockouts.



Cutting back to the match, the Sunrisers did not have a particularly bright beginning to the chase, losing Travis Head early.

Abhishek Sharma too struggled for his timing, crawling to a 21-ball 26 as SRH could not find momentum in the Power Play, which they

ended on 45 for one.

But once Klaasen, who was dropped on 18 by Spencer Johnson off Noor Ahmad, joined Kishan, the complexion of the game changed.

The duo neutralised CSK spinners -- Akeal Hossain and Ahmad -- with exem-

plary shot-making and foot work during their alliance as SRH closed in on the target.

Kishan completed his 50 in 37 balls but lost Klaasen to a brilliant stumping by Sanju Samson off Ahmad. However, the left-hander, who played some brilliant shots around the field, converted that fifty

into something more substantial to drive his side's charge.

However, he was not there to take SRH home as he fell to Anshul Kamboj but by then the 2016 champions needed just six runs to win.

Earlier, pacer Cummins displayed his absolute control over his craft, but a collective batting effort helped CSK reach a competitive 180/7.

The Hyderabad skipper (3/28) struck at crucial junctures of the match to ensure that CSK would not embark on a lopsided run after the home side elected to bat.

Samson gave a thunderous start to the Super Kings, smashing Nitish Kumar Reddy for 6, 4, 4, to eke out 17 runs in the first over.

Samson handed an equally harsh treatment to Praful Hinge in the next over, biffing him for a hat-trick of fours.

But Cummins introduced himself in the third over, and pitched one up at good pace, and Samson's booming drive ended in the safe mitts of stumper Ishan Kishan.

Urvil Patel gave an early warning of hitting abilities with two successive sixes off Cummins, but Sakib Hussain's slow ball beat his horizontal bat to rattle the stumps.

It was class bowling in last six overs: DC skipper Axar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Capitals skipper Axar Patel lauded his bowlers, particularly "youngster" Mitchell Starc, for helping the team fight back in the last six overs and score an important five-wicket win over Rajasthan Royals in their IPL match here on Sunday.

The win swelled DC's tally to 12 points from 13 matches with a game in hand, but it also gave them an outside chance to enter the playoffs if they win their final fixture next Sunday, provided some other results go their way.

"We bowled really well in the middle overs to make a comeback. The last six overs, it was class bowling. The bowling unit refused to give up. Our 'youngster' (Starc) did that for us today," Axar said in the post-match presentation here on Sunday.

Axar also said the opening stand of 105 between KL Rahul (56) and Abhishek Porel (51) eased pressure on the middle-order batters.

"It's obviously special to win at home. One thing has improved that we used to lose wickets in clusters easily, but today we got a good opening stand which



helped the other batters."

Player of the match Starc said the DC bowling unit fought back well.

"We didn't bowl too badly in the powerplay but they batted well. But we brought

things back later and KL batted fantastically, and to finish at home with a win is always nice. Adjusting as quickly as you can is key because boundaries aren't too big here," said the pacer.

Goa to host 5th Asia Cup Bridge Championships from June 21

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Goa

The prestigious fifth Asia Cup Bridge Championships will be held from June 21-27 at the Taj Cidade de Goa Horizon, Goa, the Bridge Federation of India (BFI), the apex governing body for the game of contract bridge in the country, announced on Monday.

Held once in four years, the Asia Cup ranks among the most distinguished continental Bridge Championships, conducted under the aegis of the Asia Bridge fraternity, with participation from leading nations across Asia and Oceania.

This year, the championship is expected to welcome participants from over 20 countries, including India, China, Japan, Chinese Taipei, Hong Kong China, Singapore, Thailand, Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Korea, Australia, New Zealand, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Pakistan, United Arab Emirates, Jordan, Kuwait



and Saudi Arabia.

Prasad Keni, president of BFI said, "This is the second time India has been honoured to host the prestigious Asia Cup Bridge Championship. It highlights India's growing stature as a premier destination for global mind sports and intellectual sporting events."

"Furthermore, it significantly boosts Goa's positioning as a dynamic hub for international sporting tourism, proving that the state can seamlessly merge world-class leisure with competitive, high-intellect global tournaments."

Bumrah's workload, Rohit's fitness in focus

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Guwahati

Pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah's workload management will be debated alongside the match fitness of Rohit Sharma when the national selectors pick India's squads for next month's one-off Test and three ODIs against Afghanistan, here on Tuesday.

There is a short turnaround between the IPL and the one off Test which begins in Mullanpur (New Chandigarh) from June 6. The IPL final is scheduled on May 31 in Ahmedabad.

The ODI games will take place in Dharamsala, Lucknow and Chennai on June 14, 17 and 20.

It is unlikely that Bumrah would be picked for both formats because there is no immediate rush for him to feature in ODIs. The 50-over World Cup is still a long way off (October-November, 2027).

Rohit had missed a chunk of Mumbai Indians' matches earlier in the IPL due to a hamstring injury



and in the last game against Punjab Kings, he only came out to bat as an impact player.

The selectors will include him in the side only if he is fully fit for 100 overs of an ODI game.

Superstar Virat Kohli, who like Rohit is now a one format player, has shown sublime form in the IPL and is expected to feature in all three ODIs against Afghanistan.

The one-off Test holds more significance considering India's troubles in the traditional format especially at home.

The batters need to find a way to tackle spin-friendly conditions. It is an aspect that has bothered them for a while now and was thoroughly exposed by South Africa in the home series last November.

India has also not been able to find a stable number three since Cheteshwar Pujara left the scene.

Sai Sudharsan got his chances but could not deliver. And now Devdutt Padikkal is expected to be given a decent run from the start of the home season.

Royals need all-round fix in must-win against LSG



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jaipur

Their playoff hopes hanging by a thread, the Rajasthan Royals will need an all-round improvement against the out-of-contention Lucknow Super Giants to stay alive in the Indian Premier League here on Tuesday.

At the high-scoring Sawai Mansingh Stadium, Royals are yet to win a game this season and the final fixture here is a do or die one for the home team.

Following Tuesday's fixture, the Royals' last game is also against a vanquished outfit — the Mumbai Indians.

In Delhi on Sunday night, RR should have out-batted Delhi Capitals but a lower order collapse cost them the match in which their fielding and bowling was also fairly ordinary. Royals have been relying heavily on 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi for flying starts but the youngster has not got enough support from Yashasvi Jaiswal at the other end.

Would love to own a team in WPL: Mohit Burman

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

The BCCI may have ruled out an immediate expansion of the Women's Premier League (WPL) but IPL side Punjab Kings co-owner Mohit Burman says the franchise would love to own a team in the four-season-old tournament at some point.

The WPL currently has three teams owned by IPL franchises — Mumbai Indians, Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Delhi Capitals.

While the BCCI has no immediate plans to add to the existing five-team WPL, Burman is bullish about the growth of the game globally and would be happy to invest in the league when the opportunity arises.

"The WPL has already established itself as an important platform for the



women's game in a very short period of time. The growth of women's cricket has been fantastic to witness," Burman, who owns 48 per cent stake in Punjab Kings, said.

Lalthantluangi picked for Australia tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Defender Lalthantluangi on Monday received her maiden senior team call-up for the upcoming tour of Australia, where seasoned mid-fielder Salima Tete will lead the Indian women's hockey team.

The tour, scheduled from May 26 to 30 in Perth, is a part of preparation for the FIH Hockey Women's Nations Cup 2025-26, which will be held in Auckland from June 15-21.

The Indian team heads into the tour on the back of a strong showing in Argentina earlier this year, where it displayed plenty of fight to secure two wins in the four-match series.

Salima, a bronze medalist at the 2022 Commonwealth Games and Asian Games, will have plenty of experience alongside her with the likes of Savita, Sushila Chanu Pukhrabam, Lalremsiami and



Navneet Kaur, as well as exciting young talent including Sonam, Hina Bano and Lalthantluangi.

Savita and Bichu Devi Kharibam will be the reliable options in the goal-keeping department. In defence, Nikki Pradhan, Ishika Chaudhary, Sushila Chanu Pukhrabam, Lalthantluangi and Iyoti will feature alongside Shilpi Dabas, who has earned her maiden

senior team call-up.

"We have picked a squad with a good balance of experienced and young players, some of whom will get their first minutes at the international level. It's important to keep developing players, and the best way to do that is under pressure in international matches," Chief coach Sjoerd Marijne said.

T20's six-hitting era turns cricket bat-making into a science of precision, customisation

MR MISHRA ■ New Delhi

May 18 (PTI) Cricket's relentless shift towards power-hitting has sparked a quiet revolution far from the spotlight inside bat manufacturing units, where traditional willow craftsmanship is giving way to scientific precision as makers race to meet the demands of modern-day batters.

Driven by the high-stakes world of franchise cricket, where marginal gains can decide fortunes, manufacturers are now fine-tuning bats through moisture control, fibre analysis and personalised design to suit each



player's strength, strokeplay and match situation.

The pressure to perform in an era of franchise valuations running into hundreds of crores



of rupees, where every boundary can tilt match outcomes and justify massive team-building investments, has created an unprecedented demand for



hyper-customised bats.

For now, manufacturers are already leaning heavily on scientific data, analyst feedback and player-specific profiling to design

bats that can maximise performance.

And the day is not far when the inevitable Artificial Intelligence will help engineers make the bats, they say.

From powerplay specialists to death-over finishers, many top batters now travel with eight to 10 bats, each calibrated for a particular purpose.

"Cricketers use different types of bats at different stages of the game, depending on the situation. On an average, they carry eight to 10 bats. They know each of their bats well and number them," Paras Anand, CEO of

Sanspareils Greenlands (SG), one of India's leading bat manufacturers, said in an interview.

The phenomenon underlines how cricket has evolved from the days when players often nurtured one trusted bat through entire seasons. Today's generation wants instant performance.

"Earlier batsmen used to prepare the bats by first playing in the nets and knocking them in. But today's generation wants a ready-to-use bat. Otherwise they say the bat is not good. Players say, 'I have a match in the evening, send me the bat before that,'" Anand explained.